

A close-up portrait of a male soccer player, likely from Arsenal, wearing a yellow and blue striped jersey. He is smiling and looking upwards and to the right. The jersey features the Adidas logo, the Arsenal crest, and the name 'KAZEE' on the front.

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PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

She has already announced limits on official vehicles used by ministers, MLAs and other public representatives. The chief minister also urged Delhi residents to adopt carpooling and make greater use of buses and metro services instead of private vehicles in view of the prevailing global



Delhi Minister Kapil Mishra travelled by the metro, saying the move was part of the Government's effort to implement Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal to reduce fuel consumption and promote energy

PWD minister Parvesh Sahib Singh also directed that virtual meetings be

From minimising vehicle use and promoting electric mobility to encouraging officers to travel together and hold virtual meetings.

The directions included minimum, need-based use of official vehicles, use of public transport, EVs, car pooling and speedy electrification of the vehicle fleet. During inspections, inaugurations and official events, officers will preferably travel together using EVs or pooled vehicles and public transport.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

The Chief Minister said fuel conservation should become a public movement and stressed that small individual efforts could collectively make a significant difference in the national interest. "The Government has decided to limit the use of official vehicles for departmental work. Public transport and carpooling will be given priority," the Chief



The Chief Minister said public participation was necessary to achieve larger national goals. Referring to the Covid-19 period, she said the country had previously shown discipline and cooperation during difficult situations and could do so again through responsible use of transport resources.

According to Government figures, Delhi Metro currently operates more than 4,500 trips daily through 343 trains and 303 stations. The network serves over 65 lakh passengers every day across Delhi, Noida, Greater Noida, Gurugram, Faridabad, Ghaziabad, and Bahadurgarh.

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 New Delhi

Employees permitted to work from home have been asked to remain accessible through official communica-

"These include sanitation and public health field staff, hospital and dispensary staff, emergency services personnel, electricity and water supply operational staff, field engineering and maintenance teams, enforcement and inspection staff, and control room and emergency response personnel," the order read.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

The advisory, issued by the office of the additional commissioner, said the



According to the advisory, all officers and officials have been advised to prefer-

The civic body has also asked staff residing in nearby localities to coordinate and adopt carpooling arrangements to minimise the use of individual vehicles. "Unnecessary use of personal vehicles, particularly for routine commuting and non-essential movement, should be avoided," the advisory read. It further directed that, as

Heads of departments and controlling officers have been asked to sensitise staff under their control regarding sustainable and eco-friendly practices, including the use of public transport, carpooling and virtual platforms, advisory read.



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IN FOCUS



Tourists participate in river rafting in the Beas river during the summer season at Manali in Kullu district, Himachal Pradesh

PTI

Prateek Yadav’s sudden demise heartbreaking: Yogi Adityanath

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Wednesday said that the “sudden demise” of Prateek Yadav was “extremely heartbreaking” as he extended his condolences to the family.

Prateek, 38, was the younger son of Samajwadi Party founder the late Mulayam Singh Yadav and stepbrother of party president Akhilesh Yadav. He died earlier this morning at the civil hospital, where he was rushed around 6 am.

“The sudden demise of Shri Prateek Yadav ji, son of former Chief Minister of Uttar Pradesh, ‘Padma Vibhushan’, the late Mulayam Singh Yadav ji, and husband of Smt. Aparna Yadav ji, Vice-



Chairperson of the Uttar Pradesh State Women’s Commission, is extremely heartbreaking. Humble tribute,” Adityanath posted on X.

“My condolences are with the bereaved family. I pray to

Lord Shri Ram that the departed soul attains eternal peace and the grieving family is granted the strength to bear this immense sorrow. Om Shanti!” he added.

Although hailing from a prominent political family,

Prateek, a fitness enthusiast, had stayed away from active politics.

However, his wife, Aparna Bisht Yadav, joined the BJP and is currently the vice chairperson of the State Women Commission.

Gujarat restricts convoy facility for CM, deputy CM



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gandhinagar

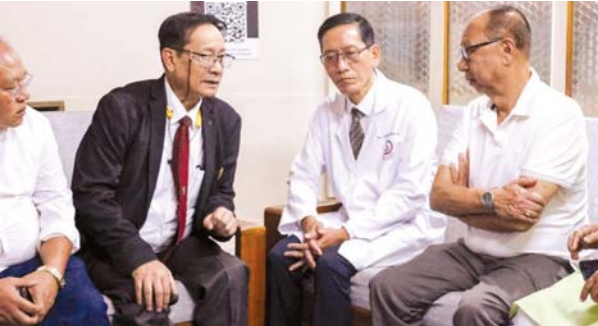
In a major administrative move aimed at encouraging fuel conservation and reducing unnecessary expenditure, the Gujarat Government has decided to withdraw official convoy facilities for ministers placed under the “non-category” classification.

The decision follows PM Narendra Modi’s recent appeal to reduce petrol and

diesel consumption across the country. Acting on the call, the state administration has begun implementing several austerity measures involving official travel and security arrangements.

Under the revised protocol, only Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel and Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghani will continue to receive limited convoy facilities. All other ministers will no longer be entitled to official convoys during travel.

Fresh violence rocks Manipur, three killed



Manipur CM Y Khemchand Singh and others visit the injured at the Shija Hospitals and Research Institute in Imphal

PTI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Imphal

In fresh violence in Manipur on Wednesday, suspected militants shot three church leaders dead and injured four others in Kangpokpi district, while a civilian was gunned down and his wife wounded in Noney district, officials said.

The Kangpokpi incident happened in the morning hours at a place between Kotzim and Kotlen villages when members of the Thadou Baptist Association (TBA) were returning from Churachandpur after attending a religious congregation.

The second incident occurred at a place between Jouzangtek and Nungsai villages in Noney district around

8 pm.

After the Kangpokpi ambush, Chief Minister Y Khemchand Singh stated that such “senseless acts of violence” against innocent civilians threaten peace in Manipur which has been rocked by ethnic violence since 2023.

Chief Ministers of Mizoram and Manipur condemned the killing of church leaders and sought immediate arrest of the culprits.

Following the killings, a total shutdown was imposed in Kangpokpi district where Kukis are in the majority.

A forum of Naga legislators and a Kuki organisation also deplored the killings, while a Meitei group rejected allegations from some quarters that it was behind the ambush.

Police to challege HC bail granted to school caretaker in child assault case

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police is preparing to challenge the bail granted to the 57-year-old school caretaker in the case involving the alleged sexual assault of a three-year-old girl inside a West Delhi school, taking the matter to the Delhi High Court.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (West) Darade Sharad Bhaskar told *The Pioneer*, “We are in the process of filing an appeal in the High Court against the bail granted to the accused in the matter”.

A court in Dwarka granted bail to the accused on May 7 after noting that the child’s medical examination revealed no signs of injury or redness. Police sources also said investigators were getting assistance from the forensic department in gathering evidence against the accused.

The court also took note of CCTV footage that allegedly showed the caretaker leaving the junior wing of the school in the morning and not returning during the period when the assault was alleged to have taken place.



The alleged incident took place on April 30, the child’s second day at the school in Janakpuri.

According to the complaint filed by the girl’s mother on May 1, the child told her that a staff member had taken her to an isolated area and assaulted her.

After the toddler identified the caretaker, police arrested him.

They booked him under Section 64 of the *Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita* and provisions of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act.

Meanwhile, the incident has also triggered administrative action against the

school. Reports said the Directorate of Education (DoE) issued a show-cause notice to the institution on May 8, warning of and threatening to take over its management over what it described as “grave lapses” in child safety and supervision.

The school was directed to submit a detailed response by May 11, failing which it could face withdrawal of recognition and cancellation of its land lease.

Delhi Police officials said the investigation into the case remains underway even as it moves to challenge the bail order before the High Court.

Tehran welcomes India’s peace initiative; slams BRICS member over West Asia

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Iran on Wednesday said it would welcome any peace initiative by India to de-escalate tensions in West Asia, while accusing one member country of blocking a consensus within BRICS on the ongoing regional conflict.

Speaking to a select group of journalists in New Delhi ahead of the BRICS foreign ministers’ conclave, Iranian Deputy Foreign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi said differences within the grouping had prevented the issuance of a unified statement on the crisis.

“We want India’s BRICS chairship to be successful. It is not a good approach to send a signal to the world that BRICS is divided,” Gharibabadi said. “One country is insisting on condemning Iran.”

Though he did not name the country directly, his remarks appeared to be aimed at the United Arab Emirates, which, along with Iran, joined BRICS during the bloc’s expansion in 2024.

“We have not attacked neighbouring countries. They handed over their territories to the US to launch attacks on us,” he said. “We



never insisted that Arab countries should be condemned because they allowed their military bases to the United States.”

The Iranian deputy foreign minister praised India’s role as BRICS chair, describing New Delhi’s approach as “impartial” amid sharp divisions within the grouping over the US-Israel conflict involving Iran.

The comments come a day before India hosts the BRICS foreign ministers’ meeting, which is expected to focus extensively on the West Asia crisis and its impact on global energy security. Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi and Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov are among the leaders attending the conclave chaired by External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar.

Gharibabadi said Tehran viewed India as a credible and balanced actor capable

of contributing to regional stability.

“India has always supported peace. It is in favour of peace and stability in the region,” he said. “We will welcome whatever initiative India takes for peace.”

Responding to a question on Pakistan’s reported role as a facilitator between Tehran and Washington, he said Iran remained open to all diplomatic channels.

“Pakistan is only a facilitator. We will welcome all such initiatives,” he said.

Gharibabadi, who was part of Iran’s negotiating team during talks with the United States, accused Washington of undermining diplomacy and prolonging the conflict.

“The US is not serious about ending the war through diplomacy,” he claimed, adding that Iran would fully reopen maritime access once Washington lifted sanctions, ended what he called a naval blockade and released frozen Iranian assets.

The Iranian official also reiterated Tehran’s commitment to the Chabahar port project and said India could decide how to proceed given continuing US sanctions linked to the initiative.

Four more arrested for NEET paper leak

Social media platforms have been flooded with messages of outrage and demands for a thorough, time-bound investigation. The Ministry of Education has been closely monitoring the probe and has assured full cooperation to the CBI.

A senior official, speaking on condition of anonymity, emphasised that the government remains “absolutely committed to upholding the sanctity and transparency of all competitive examinations.” The National Testing Agency (NTA), which conducts NEET, is also expected to issue a detailed statement once the investigation makes further progress.

This is not the first time that competitive examinations in India have come under the scanner for alleged leaks. Similar incidents in recent years had prompted the enactment of the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024, which prescribes stringent punishments, including jail terms of up to ten years and heavy fines. The CBI’s swift action in the present case is being seen as a strong message that the new law will be enforced without exception.

The agency has appealed to the general public, candidates, coaching institutes and any other stakeholders possessing credible information to come forward and assist the investigation. It has also cautioned against the circulation of unverified rumours that could hamper the probe or cause unnecessary panic among students.

The CBI is expected to file its first status report in the competent court within the next few days. With the investigation still in its early but intensive phase, further arrests, seizures and revelations are anticipated. For now, the focus remains on ensuring that the culprits are brought to justice quickly and that the faith of millions of young Indians in the fairness of the medical admission process is restored, an official added.

Govt raises import duty on gold to conserve...

Consequential changes have also been made to other items such as gold/silver dore, coins, findings. The duty hike came within days of Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s clarion call for curbs on gold purchases, along with other austerity measures to reduce avoidable foreign exchange expenditure. Industry experts say the decision will lead to a sharp decline in sales of gold jewellery and coins, but will spur old gold exchange within the economy.

Another sources said the ongoing war in West Asia is expected to balloon India’s import bill, and the government wants to prioritise forex expen-

diture towards essential imports like crude oil, fertilisers, industrial raw materials and capital goods that directly support economic activity and food security. A notification issued by the finance ministry shows the Government increased the Social Welfare

The impact of the duty hike would be visible in the retail inflation data of May, and a full picture would be visible only in June. As international prices of gold remain elevated, the duty hike is not likely to have much of an impact on the Current Account Deficit (CAD), as even lower imports would come in at a costlier price. Besides, the rupee is likely to remain under pressure, as is evident from the currency touching a record low of 95.80 to a dollar. Historically, import duty hikes have resulted in lower volumes of imports, but elevated global prices have kept the import bill high.

Gold imports in India, the world’s second biggest gold consumer after China, are driven by the jewellery industry demand. Such imports involve substantial outflow of foreign exchange.

India’s gold imports surged more than 24 per cent to an all-time high of \$71.98 billion in 2025-26. In volume terms, however, the shipments dipped 4.76 per cent to 721.03 tonnes in 2025-26. The prices of gold have risen from \$76,617.48/KG in FY25 to \$99,825.38/KG in FY26.

In the national capital, the price of gold increased by ₹1,500, or nearly 1 per cent, to ₹1,56,800 per 10 grams on Tuesday from Monday’s closing level of ₹1,55,300 per 10 grams. Silver prices also advanced by ₹12,000, or 4.53 per cent, to ₹2,77,000 per kg. In the international market, spot gold slipped \$42.33, or 1 per cent, to \$4,692.64 per ounce while silver fell 3.04 per cent to \$83.49 per ounce.

Jewellers and industry leaders on Wednesday said the hike in import duty on gold and silver could impact jewellery volumes in the short term, though demand is expected to remain resilient due to the yellow metal’s enduring cultural and investment appeal in India. India had allowed imports of gold from Dubai at tariffs one percentage point below the normal Most-Favoured-Nation (MFN) rate through a Tariff Rate Quota (TRQ) system. The quota began at 120 tonnes annually in 2022 and is set to rise to 200 tonnes by 2027, nearly one-fourth of India’s yearly gold imports.

Over 85 per cent pass CBSE class 12 exams

He said the number of students placed in compartment rose to 1,63,800 (9.26 per cent) in 2026, up from 1,29,095 (7.63 per cent) in 2025. It means that these student may have failed in one or two

FROM PAGE - 1

subjects in the main board exam but have passed in the other subjects. Transgender candidates achieved a 100 per cent pass rate.

Students placed in compartment or wishing to improve performance in one subject may appear in the supplementary examination scheduled for July 15, officials said. The ‘List of Candidates’ (LOC) submission window will open on June 2.

Trump gets red carpet welcome in Beijing

Trump’s son Eric and his daughter-in-law Lara, as well as Tesla chief Elon Musk, disembarked from Air Force One along with Trump.

Accompanying Trump on his trip to China are some of the US’s top business leaders.

Nvidia’s Jensen Huang, Tim Cook of Apple, Musk of Tesla and SpaceX, and Larry Fink of BlackRock, are among those travelling with the US president.

“I will be asking President Xi, a Leader of extraordinary distinction, to ‘open up’ China so that these brilliant people can work their magic, and help bring the People’s Republic to an even higher level,” Trump said in a post on social media. Trump said that it will be his “very first request” when he meets the Chinese leader, BBC reported. “I have never seen or heard of any idea that would be more beneficial to our incredible Countries,” he said.

The last-minute addition of Nvidia’s Jensen Huang to Trump’s delegation was regarded as significant, as semiconductor chips are central to the US-China technology rivalry.

China is bargaining for semiconductor chips for its AI tech development, while the US wants the rare-earth minerals used for manufacturing mobile phones and aircraft jets.

Ahead of Trump’s arrival, Chinese Vice Premier He Lifeng and Scott Bessent completed the final round of trade negotiations in South Korea, details of which are not known.

The next two days, Trump and Xi are scheduled to hold several rounds of talks to discuss both bilateral and global issues, especially the Iran war. The talks are expected to focus on trade and tariffs, Artificial Intelligence and technology, Taiwan and US’ arms sales to Taipei, Iran and West Asia East security and rare earths and supply chains. Trump’s schedule in Beijing included a visit to the Temple of Heaven, a complex of imperial temples where emperors would pray for a good harvest.

Ahead of his departure for Beijing, Trump told the media in Washington he would be talking with Xi about trade more than anything else. He plans to sign more deals with China to buy more

American food and aircraft. The two countries also plan to set up a Board of Trade with China to address differences between the countries.

From a trade point of view, China looks to reap a rich harvest as Trump is accompanied by top CEOs of US multinational giants, including Tesla chief Musk and Apple CEO Cook, who have well-entrenched businesses in China.

The global focus on the summit, however, would be on any possible outcome that could end the US-Israeli war against Iran and end the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz.

Ahead of Trump’s visit, Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi made his first visit to Beijing after the war and held talks with his Chinese counterpart Wang Yi. The US watched his visit closely as China is the largest importer of Iranian oil and shares strategic defence ties with Tehran, and has considerable influence over Iran.

After talks with Araghchi, Wang called on Iran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz as soon as possible, even as it appreciated Tehran’s commitment not to develop nuclear weapons, a prime demand of Trump to end the war.

Commenting on Wang-Araghchi talks, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio said, “I hope the Chinese tell him what he needs to be told. And that is what you are doing in the Strait, which is causing you to be globally isolated. You’re the bad guy in this.” China’s anxieties over the Iran war increased, especially after Trump imposed a blockade of Iranian ports, restricting Iran’s oil exports to China.

Bert Hoffman, former World Bank country director for China, said China wants the Iran war to end because it has many partners in the region, including Saudi Arabia, the UAE and Kuwait. “So they don’t like to see wars, they like to have stability,” he said.

In its editorial on Trump’s visit, state-run Global Times said Xi has held multiple telephone conversations and meetings with him, which have helped correct the course of the bilateral relationship and steer it clear of hidden dangers at critical moments. For China-US relations to truly stabilise and improve in the future, the most fundamental step is to fully and faithfully implement the important consensus reached by both leaders, it said. From China’s point of view, the Taiwan issue was expected to figure prominently in the talks.

Last week, Foreign Minister Wang told Rubio, during their telephone talks, that the US should make the right choice about the self-ruled Taiwan.

China claims Taiwan as part of its own and has been ramping up military pressure on the island with periodic military drills around the island. (PTI)

TVK Govt wins maiden trust vote with ease

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

The four-day-old TVK Government in Tamil Nadu crossed a major hurdle on Wednesday, comfortably winning the trust vote with the support of 25 rebel AIADMK MLAs amid DMK's walkout. The Opposition made allegations of horse-trading that were rejected by Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay.

In its confidence-boosting win, TVK romped home by a 144:22 margin, with all the 22 naysayers being the AIADMK MLAs owing allegiance to party chief Edappadi K Palaniswami. The 25 other party MLAs, from the C Ve Shanmugam-SP Velumani camp, voted in favour of the Government.

Replying to discussions over the resolution moved by him seeking vote of confidence, Vijay said his Government will always be secular and would continue



Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay speaks in the state Assembly during floor test in Chennai PTI

to implement the welfare schemes launched by previous regimes. While the main opposition DMK, with 59 MLAs in the 234-member House staged a walkout slamming the Government, PMK with 4 MLAs and the lone member of the BJP abstained.

The Vijay-led TVK Government got support from

the Congress, VCK, Left, IUML and MLA S Kamaraj, who was expelled from AMMK for supporting TVK. In an embarrassment, the split in the AIADMK came into the open during the trust vote proceedings as the faction led by party leaders Velumani-Shanmugam voted in favour of the Government. Though minutes before

Velumani announced support, Palaniswami had declared in the House that his party MLAs must vote against the government. The Velumani-Shanmugam-led group defied the diktat and sided with the TVK regime. Noisy scenes were witnessed as Palaniswami's faction opposed Velumani-

TN GOVT REVOKES APPOINTMENT OF ASTROLOGER AS OSD TO CM VIJAY

Chennai: The Tamil Nadu Government on Wednesday revoked its order appointing Rickey Radhan Pandit Vetrivel, an astrologer, as the Officer on Special Duty (OSD - Political) to Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay.

The decision to withdraw the Government Order (GO) comes less than 24 hours after the appointment was made on Tuesday, following a wave of sharp criticism from political opponents

and allies of the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) alike.

The appointment had sparked a heated debate in the State Assembly earlier in the day. Opposition leaders, including DMDK general secretary Premalatha Vijayakanth, strongly condemned the move on the floor of the House, questioning the induction of an astrologer into a key political administrative role.

Shanmugam group's announcement of support to the Government.

In the 234-member House, 118 is the simple majority mark, and at the time of voting TVK — which won 108 seats — had a strength of 105, as one party MLA was barred from voting by court; Vijay resigned from Tiruchi-East and Speaker JCD Prabhakar

cannot vote in the absence of a "tie" situation. Speaker JCD Prabhakar, after conducting the voting exercise, declared that the resolution moved by the chief minister seeking vote of confidence of the Assembly has won, and as many as 144 MLAs voted with the government; 22 MLAs opposed, and five took a neutral stand.

Mother Dairy, Amul hike milk prices



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Mother Dairy and Amul have increased milk prices across several variants, with the revised rates set to take effect from May 14, according to updated price charts and circulars issued by the companies. The latest revisions cover key milk categories sold by both brands, including full cream milk, toned milk, cow milk, buffalo milk and premium variants across multiple markets.

Amul, marketed by the Gujarat Cooperative Milk Marketing Federation (GCMMF), has increased prices by ₹1-2 per litre across most variants. Amul Gold milk in the 1-litre pack will now cost ₹70, up from ₹68, while Amul Taaza 1-litre milk has been revised to ₹57 from ₹55.

The cooperative has also raised prices of buffalo milk, cow milk, Slim & Trim and Tea Special variants. Indian Buffalo Milk in the 500 ml pack will now retail at ₹39 from ₹38, while Cow Milk has been revised to ₹30 from ₹29 for the same pack size.

Mother Dairy has also revised prices across multiple stock-keeping units (SKUs), according to a circular dated May 13 addressed to distributors and transporters.

The milk price hike is likely to impact food inflation and pinch the budget of middle-class consumers. The last price increase was effected on May 1, 2025.

GCMMF, in a statement, said it has "increased the prices of fresh pouch milk by Rs 2 per litre in major milk-selling variants/packs across India effective from May 14". The increase translates to about 2.5-3.5 per cent per litre, which is lower than the average food inflation, it added.

In a statement, Mother Dairy said it has revised the consumer prices of its liquid milk variants by ₹2 per litre, effective May 14, 2026. The last price revision was done in late April 2025. "The revision has been necessitated in view of the sustained increase in farmer procurement prices, of around 6 per cent over the past one year, despite continued efforts to limit the impact on consumers," it said.

Mother Dairy said this price revision represents only a partial pass-through of increased costs and is aimed at "maintaining a fair balance between farmer welfare and consumer interests".

Mother Dairy said it passes on nearly 75-80 per cent of its milk sales realisation to farmers.

Air India to cut nearly 100 overseas flights

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Air India will cut nearly 100 overseas flights and temporarily suspend services on seven routes, including Delhi-Chicago, that will result in up to a 27 per cent reduction between June and August compared with April, as prolonged airspace restrictions and soaring aviation fuel prices amid the West Asia war weigh on their viability.

More than 100 weekly or over 400 monthly international services will be reduced during the next three months, as per calculations based on details of flight reductions provided by the airline in the statement. The sharp reduction adds to the mounting operational and financial challenges for the Tata Group carrier.

The airline said the tempo-



rary changes were aimed at improving operational stability and reducing last-minute inconvenience to passengers as global aviation continues to face disruptions linked to the Iran war crisis and instability around the Strait of Hormuz.

In a statement, Air India said, "The adjustments have been made in response to a combination of factors, including continued airspace restrictions over certain regions and record-high jet

fuel prices for international operations, which significantly impact the commercial viability of certain planned services." Despite the cuts, the airline said it would continue operating more than 1,200 international flights every month across five continents.

The carrier will be temporarily suspending services on Delhi-Chicago, Delhi-Newark, Mumbai-New York, Delhi-Shanghai, Chennai-Singapore, Mumbai-Dhaka,

and Delhi-Male routes till August. While announcing the rationalisation of services, Air India also said it "may make further adjustments to its network should the extraordinary operating environment prevail".

On the North America routes, the airlines will reduce at least 10 weekly flights apart from the temporary suspension of Delhi-Chicago services.

Air India will cut 12 weekly flights on the Europe network, while the reduction will be six weekly services on the Australia front, according to the statement. There will be up to a reduction of 68 weekly flights in the Far East, Southeast Asia, and SAARC networks.

The airline said it would continue to operate more than 1,200 international flights every month.

CBI extradites red notice fugitive Prabhdeep Singh from Azerbaijan

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), in coordination with the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), and Delhi Police, has successfully secured the extradition of the Red Notice subject, Prabhdeep Singh, from Azerbaijan to India.

A three-member escort team from Delhi Police brought him back to the capital on Wednesday morning. This is a significant success for India's anti-narcotics efforts in extraditing fugitive Prabhdeep Singh, described as the main organiser of a large-scale narcotics trafficking syndicate from Azerbaijan.

Prabhdeep was wanted in connection with a case registered at Delhi Police's



Prabhdeep Singh

Special Cell Police Station under various provisions of the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act, 1985. The investigation into the racket had earlier led to the recovery of a substantial quantity of narcotic substances and the arrest of several co-accused persons. Officials identified Singh as the key conspirator and primary organiser who

allegedly ran the entire narcotics network.

According to the CBI, Prabhdeep had fled India after the case came to light. At the request of the Delhi Police, the CBI secured an Interpol Red Notice against him. Through sustained international coordination and intelligence sharing, Azerbaijani authorities geo-located and arrested him in Baku.

Following formal extradition proceedings via diplomatic channels involving the Ministries of Home Affairs and External Affairs, Azerbaijan handed him over to Indian authorities after completing all legal formalities. A CBI spokesperson said, "In the said case, a substantial quantity of narcotic substance was recovered, and several co-accused persons were arrested. The subject was the main organ-

iser of this narcotics racket."

The agency emphasised that the operation was a coordinated effort by the CBI, Delhi Police, MEA, and MHA, highlighting India's growing success in bringing fugitives back through Interpol and bilateral cooperation. Officials noted that over 160 wanted criminals have been repatriated in recent years under similar initiatives.

Prabhdeep Singh's criminal involvement centres on his alleged role as the mastermind behind an international narcotics syndicate operating out of Delhi. While exact details of the drug quantity, specific substances involved, or the timeline of the original raids remain limited in public statements, police sources have consistently portrayed him as the central figure who orchestrated the supply, distribution, and financial

operations of the racket.

Several lower-level operatives linked to the syndicate were arrested during the initial probe, but Singh evaded capture by fleeing abroad. Upon arrival in Delhi, Prabhdeep was taken into custody for further legal proceedings. His extradition is being seen as a major blow to organised drug syndicates that exploit international routes to evade Indian law enforcement.

This case underscores the growing effectiveness of India's use of Interpol Red Notices and diplomatic extradition channels, particularly in narcotics-related cases that threaten public health and national security. Meanwhile, investigations into the broader illicit network of drug peddlers are ongoing, Special Cell sources said.

Ozempic counterfeit scam: Delhi Police issue Lookout Circular against alleged mastermind Swapnadip Roy

RANJIT KUMAR SINHA
■ New Delhi

The investigation into the ₹157 crore international counterfeit Ozempic scam, which sent shockwaves through the global pharmaceutical community, has escalated with a primary focus now shifting toward Dubai-based Indian national Swapnadip Roy.

Sources confirm that the Economic Offences Wing (EOW) of the Delhi Police has officially issued a Lookout Circular (LOC) against Roy. This move aims to prevent his movement across international borders and ensure his apprehension, as he is currently believed to be hiding in Dubai. The hunt for Roy intensified after Vicky Ramancha, CEO of R&R Global Procurement Corp., and the initial central figure in the probe, disclosed Roy's name during the investigation.

Ramancha alleged that Roy, an Indian passport holder from Tripura, was the "key architect" who orchestrated the entire transnational scam. Despite multiple notices sent to his Tripura address and a



formal summons under the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), Roy has remained elusive.

The EOW has now categorised him as a key accused, seeking to unearth a conspiracy that spans India, Dubai, China, and the USA.

The case began when US-based Assure Global LLC alleged that they were duped out of approximately \$18.8 million (approximately ₹157 crore). The firm had entered into a deal for 1.25 lakh doses of Ozempic, a high-demand anti-diabetic and weight-loss drug. Instead of genuine medication, the company alleged-

ly received "spurious" or misbranded drugs shipped from China, which were subsequently seized by US authorities. The fraud was allegedly given a veneer of legitimacy through the use of forged documents, including fake government credentials and notarised papers from the Patiala House Courts.

Funds were allegedly routed through Ramancha's Dubai-based entity, M/s RNR Premier Medical Equipments Trading LLC.

In September 2025, the Delhi Police filed a status report before the Delhi High Court, noting Roy's involve-

ment and his failure to cooperate. While the High Court had previously granted Ramancha interim protection from arrest-contingent on his cooperation-the police have highlighted that crucial financial trails, including bank statements from Dubai and proof of payment to Chinese suppliers, remain undisclosed.

The High Court is closely monitoring the progress, viewing the scam not merely as a commercial dispute-as the defence claims-but as a "sophisticated transnational fraud" and a threat to public health.

The EOW is expected to apprise the high court on the next date of hearing on July 14, 2026, of the specific steps taken to extradite or apprehend Roy, whose custodial interrogation is now seen as the "litmus test" for dismantling this global counterfeit network.

Lawyers for Assure Global have expressed hope that custodial interrogation of the key players will eventually expose the entire syndicate involved in this high-stakes conspiracy.

NIA arrests wanted narco-terrorist Iqbal Singh after extradition from Portugal

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

In yet another victory for India's counter-terrorism and anti-narcotics efforts, the National Investigation Agency (NIA) on Wednesday arrested wanted narco-terrorist Iqbal Singh alias Shera immediately upon his arrival at Delhi's Indira Gandhi International Airport following successful extradition from Portugal.

Shera, a native of Amritsar in Punjab, had been on the run since 2020 and is accused of masterminding a cross-border heroin smuggling racket that funnelled proceeds to Pakistan-based operatives of the banned Hizbul Mujahideen (HM) terror outfit to finance attacks in Jammu and Kashmir.

The arrest, described by officials as a major shot in the arm for the NIA's fight against Pakistan-backed narco and cross-border terrorism, underscores India's persistent diplomatic and legal push to bring high-profile fugitives to justice.



An NIA team took Shera into custody right off the flight from Portugal, where he had absconded after a non-bailable warrant (NBW) was issued against him in October 2020. An Interpol Red Notice had been active since June 2021.

According to the NIA, Shera was a key conspirator and handler in an India-based narco-terror module that smuggled large quantities of heroin from Pakistan into Punjab. He allegedly coordinated the entire operation, from trafficking across the border, distribution within India, and collection of sale proceeds to routing funds via

hawala networks directly to HM operatives in Pakistan and Kashmir. These proceeds were used to facilitate terror activities, including arms procurement and militant operations.

Shera reportedly maintained close links with Pakistan-based HM handlers and formed a dedicated Punjab-based terror gang to execute the conspiracy. The module operated as a sophisticated enterprise: narcotics were smuggled in and sold locally, and the drug money was systematically channelised to sustain HM's activities in the Kashmir Valley.

States Focus



CM SAINI ROLLS OUT FUEL-SAVING MEASURES

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Wednesday said he has decided to use the minimum number of vehicles in his convoy and also mentioned about a series of other initiatives his government will take following Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal for cutting down fuel consumption and spending more wisely. Saini also said ministers and officers of all departments will also ensure the use of limited vehicles during travel. Along with this, all ministers, MLAs, and officers are urged to organise the maximum number of meetings through virtual medium, he said.



USD 1 TRILLION EXPORTS TARGET FOR THIS YEAR: GOYAL

Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Wednesday asked for taking the country's goods and services exports to USD 1 trillion this fiscal year. In 2025-26, exports reached an all-time high of USD 863.11 billion, registering an increase of 4.6 per cent year-on-year, despite global economic uncertainties, including high US tariffs, the ongoing Russia-Ukraine war and the West Asia crisis, he said.

CPI(M) demands NTA disbandment over NEET paper leak

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Polit Bureau of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) on Tuesday lashed out at the Union Government over the reported leakage of the NEET examination paper, demanding the immediate disbandment of the National Testing Agency (NTA).



In a strongly worded statement, the party expressed grave concern for the nearly 22 lakh students affected by the leak, stating they are being subjected to "unnecessary psychological pressure" for a crisis they did not create. The CPI(M) alleged that such frequent leakages are the result of a nexus between corrupt elements and vested interests who remain insensitive to the plight of students.

Criticising the centralisation of the examination process, the Polit Bureau noted that this was not an isolated incident under the current regime. "This is not the first time that exam papers have been leaked after the Union Government assigned the task of conducting exams to the NTA," the statement read.

The party has called for a complete overhaul of the system, advocating for the decentralisation of examinations. It demanded that the responsibility for conducting these high-stakes tests be returned to the respective government agencies as per the earlier practice.

Demanding accountability, the CPI(M) urged the Union Government to initiate a comprehensive enquiry into the breach. The party further insisted on strict punishment for those found guilty and called for immediate measures to ensure that the academic future of the affected students is not placed in jeopardy.

States Focus



NITIN NABIN HAILS CUT IN SIZE OF PM MODI'S CONVOY

BJP president Nitin Nabin on Wednesday hailed Prime Minister Narendra Modi for reducing the number of vehicles in his cavalcade, saying the move reflects his commitment as the country's "pradhan sevak" and will inspire people to conserve resources. The prime minister has significantly reduced the size of his convoy days after appealing for austerity and urging citizens to curb the use of fuel-driven vehicles. The move has prompted several BJP chief ministers to adopt similar measures and reduce the number of vehicles in their convoys. Nabin also announced that he will reduce the number of vehicles in his convoy. In a post on social media, the BJP chief said Prime Minister Modi has once again demonstrated that he is the "true servant of the nation" by cutting down the number of vehicles in his convoy.



CM NAIDU TO UNVEIL STEPS TO MITIGATE WEST ASIA WAR IMPACT

Andhra Pradesh CM N Chandrababu Naidu on Wednesday said the State Government would unveil precautionary measures within two days to mitigate the impact of the West Asia conflict on the State. Addressing a meeting at Nidamaru village in Guntur district, the Chief Minister said Government would make an announcement in the next two days on the steps aimed at safeguarding the state from the effects of the ongoing US-Iran war. "Either tomorrow or the day after, we will also make an announcement on what preventive measures we have to take due to the effects of the war on the State," said Naidu.

Bihar CM cuts convoy size, plans weekly No Vehicle Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

Following Prime Minister Narendra Modi's call for curbing fuel consumption, Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Wednesday ordered a slash in size of his cavalcade, prompting Cabinet colleagues to follow suit. Choudhary also said that his Government is planning several steps to reduce the use of fuel, including promoting work-from-home and observing a "no vehicle day" once a week. In a post on his social media handle, a couple of days after Modi had called for austerity measures, likening the West Asia crisis to the global COVID pandemic, Choudhary announced that he was minimising the number of vehicles in his own fleet and expected ministers and other public representatives to do the same. The gesture by Choudhary, who became the first BJP leader to head a Government in Bihar last month, received a thumbs up from NDA partners in his Cabinet. At the meeting of Cabinet held in the forenoon, JD(U) ministers Ashok Choudhary, Madan Sahni and Zama Khan were seen



Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary

huddled in the same car to reach secretariat. "Yes, we have decided to take all possible measures to reduce fuel consumption. Car pooling is one of these", said Khan, who holds the minority affairs portfolio. Likewise, Sanjay Kumar Singh, the minister for public health and engineering department, who belongs to the LJP(RV), took along cabinet colleagues Sanjay Paswan and Lakhendra Paswan in his vehicle, to a function in Mahua, his Assembly constituency in Vaishali district, situated about 40 kms away from the State Capital.

Union Minister Bandi Sanjay Kumar's son skips appearance before police



Union Minister Bandi Sanjay Kumar's son Bhageerath

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

Union Minister Bandi Sanjay Kumar's son Bhageerath skipped an appearance before the police on Wednesday after being directed to appear in a POCSO case registered against him here following allegations of sexual harassment of a minor girl. Police teams continued to search for Bhageerath at different places, a police official said. A notice was served to his uncle on Tuesday, directing Bhageerath to appear before

the Inspector of Police of Pet Basheerabad police station here on May 13 at 2 pm. "However, he did not appear," the official said. Bhageerath moved the Telangana High Court seeking anticipatory bail in the case. The matter is expected to come up for hearing on May 14. The case was registered on May 8 based on a complaint by the mother of a 17-year-old girl, who alleged that Bhageerath was in a relationship with her daughter and sexually harassed her.

Jairam Ramesh flags tribal rights violations in Great Nicobar project

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Senior Congress leader Jairam Ramesh wrote to Tribal Affairs Minister Jual Oram on Wednesday, flagging "flagrant violation" of the rights of tribal communities in Great Nicobar Island Project and sought remedial action immediately. In his letter to Oram, the former environment minister termed as "entirely false" the assertion in the Government FAQs issued on May 1 that all statutory procedures and policy safeguards for the protection of tribal communities were duly complied with in the project. "The Great Nicobar Project: FAQs issued by the Union Government on May 1, 2026, stated that 'all statutory procedures and policy safeguards for the protection of tribal communities have been duly complied with in the Great Nicobar Island Project. Necessary consultations were undertaken with



competent authorities and domain experts, including the Anthropological Survey of India, Ministry of Tribal Affairs, and other stakeholders, in line with the Jarawa Policy, 2004, and Shompen Policy, 2015. This is entirely false," Ramesh said. The Ministry of Tribal Affairs, as the nodal agency for implementation of the Forest Rights Act, 2006, must take serious note of the "flagrant violation" of the rights of tribal communities and due processes under that historic law in the case of the

Great Nicobar Island Project and take credible remedial action immediately, the Congress leader demanded in his letter. "The Gram Sabha has to (i) consider any proposal for diversion of forest lands in which tribal communities live; (i) certify that their claims under the FRA, 2006 have been settled; and only thereafter (iii) consent to the diversion of such forest lands, if indeed that is its decision. The Hon'ble Supreme Court in the Niyamgiri judgment of April 18, 2023, held that such

consent is mandatory under the FRA, 2006," he pointed out. However, for the diversion of more than 13,000 hectares of forest lands for the Great Nicobar project, which includes the traditional, ancestral lands of the Nicobarese and Shompen settlements, the island administration admits to convening gram sabhas of the settler communities in Campbell Bay, Laxmi Nagar and Govind Nagar on August 12, 2022, he said. The resolutions of these gram sabhas of the settler communities are cited as consent of the gram sabhas under the FRA, 2006, Ramesh noted. The letter to Oram comes days after Ramesh wrote to Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav, claiming that the Great Nicobar Island development project would "destroy" the unique ecosystem there, and urging him to pause, reflect, and revisit the venture in its present design and detail.

TVK doesn't have support of majority voters: Udhayanidhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Tamil Nadu Leader of Opposition Udhayanidhi Stalin on Wednesday said the TVK Government did not enjoy the support of the majority voters and criticised it for going ahead with the backing of a section of legislators of the AIADMK, which the ruling party had slammed for corruption earlier. In his speech during the proceedings of the TVK Government's floor test, he also urged the Government to continue the welfare schemes that were launched by the previous DMK dispensation. The DMK walked out and abstained from voting during the confidence vote, which the C Joseph Vijay-led Government won by a comfortable margin of 144. Regarding the TVK Government for-



mation, Udhayanidhi said, "First, the majority of people did not vote for TVK." He said that in the recently concluded Assembly elections, around 4.93 crore people cast their votes. "Do you know how many voted for the ruling party, just 1.72 crore", he said, adding, "the remaining approximately 3.21 crore people voted against your party, and you must understand this". He claimed nearly 65 per cent of the voters had "rejected" the Vijay-led TVK. Further, he slammed the TVK for

taking the support of an AMMK MLA, with his party fighting the April 23 polls as a constituent of the AIADMK-led NDA in Tamil Nadu. "After saying they were your ideological enemy, you have secured support for this Government from an MLA who contested in the BJP-led NDA alliance," Udhayanidhi said. He also recalled AMMK chief TTV Dhinakaran's remarks that TVK earlier engaged in "horse-trading even before coming to power". Dhinakaran has sacked AMMK MLA S Kamaraj after the latter extended support to the TVK government. Udhayanidhi said the major party in the same BJP-led NDA alliance, AIADMK, has split almost into two groups. "A new sofa was delivered to the home of a leader from that splinter group, followed by the visit of the chief minister there. During elections, you called them (AIADMK) a corrupt force", he said.

Bihar targets 30% EV sales by 2030; hikes DA for staff

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

The Bihar Government on Wednesday approved amendments to its electric vehicle policy with the aim of ensuring that at least 30 per cent of all new vehicles sold in the State by 2030 are EVs. The decision was taken at a cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary. The move is aimed at reducing greenhouse gas emissions, curbing vehicular pollution and improving air quality across the State, officials said. "The Bihar Government aims to ensure that by 2030, at least 30 per cent of all new vehicles sold in the State are electric vehicles," the proposal approved by the Cabinet stated. The policy seeks to increase public acceptance of EVs, improve transporta-

tion facilities in rural areas and promote commercial goods-carrying electric vehicles as well as non-commercial two-wheelers and four-wheelers through incentives under the 'Chief Minister Bihar Environment-Friendly Transport Employment Scheme', officials said. Under the scheme, incentives through Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) will be provided for the purchase and registration of electric commercial goods vehicles, electric two-wheelers for women and other beneficiaries, and non-commercial four-wheelers exclusively for women, they said. The scheme would help generate employment through commercial electric vehicles while also encouraging women's mobility and empowerment, they added. Financial assistance will also be provided for setting



up EV charging stations under the existing provisions of the policy. The State Government may additionally seek grants from the Ministry of Heavy Industries under the PM E-DRIVE scheme to establish public charging infrastructure, officials said. A senior transport department officer said the PM E-DRIVE scheme aims to promote electric mobility to reduce environmental impact

and improve air quality. The Cabinet also approved an increase in Dearness Allowance (DA) for State Government employees and pensioners. Employees and pensioners covered under the 6th Central Pay Commission will receive a 5 percentage points increase in DA and Dearness Relief, from 257 per cent to 262 per cent, with effect from January 1, 2026. For employees under the

5th Central Pay Commission, DA has been increased by 9 percentage points, from 474 per cent to 483 per cent, while under the 7th Central Pay Commission, it has been raised from 58 per cent to 60 per cent. The Cabinet also approved the establishment of the Bihar Artificial Intelligence Mission. As part of the initiative, Singapore-based Global Finance and Technology Network (GFTN) has been selected to help develop Bihar's AI ecosystem, skill development and innovation initiatives. With support from GFTN and the National University of Singapore-Asian Institute of Digital Finance (NUS-AIDF), a five-month advanced AI certification programme will be launched to train around 7,000 undergraduate and postgraduate students over the next five years.

West Bengal MLAs sworn-in with religious rituals and fish meal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The inaugural day of the oath-taking ceremony of the new West Bengal MLAs on Wednesday was marked by a series of unprecedented events, including a puja within the Assembly premises and a state-sponsored fish meal for the legislators. Together, the symbolic gestures lent the Assembly proceedings a distinctive cultural and ideological char-

Former Assembly Speaker Biman Banerjee and Kamarhati MLA Madan Mitra were among those who were sworn in from the opposition Trinamool Congress camp, while BJP's Ratna Debnath, mother of the RG Kar Hospital rape and murder victim, and actor-politician Roopa Ganguly were also among those officially inducted to the House. Adhikari, who set foot inside the Assembly for the first time as chief minister,



Suvendu Adhikari takes oath as a MLA in Kolkata on Wednesday

acter, while also offering a latent statement on the Opposition's pre-poll warnings of a crackdown on people's non-vegetarian food habits by the saffron dispensation. As many as 143 MLAs of the 294-member House, including Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari, were sworn in at the State Assembly on the first of the two-day scheduled ceremony, with pro tem Speaker, Tapas Roy administering the oaths. The legislators who took their oaths belonged to both the treasury and the Opposition benches and included the newly-appointed State ministers of the State's first BJP Government – Dilip Ghosh, Agnimitra Paul, Ashok Kirtania, Kshudiram Tudu, and Nisith Pramanik.

was accorded a literal red-carpet welcome by means of an official guard of honour. The chief minister reciprocated the gesture by offering floral tributes at the statue of BR Ambedkar and then, before climbing the staircase at the Assembly portico, which leads to the building's grand hall, by kneeling down and touching his forehead to the ground as a mark of reverence to the haloed edifice. Adhikari followed up his move by offering a puja at his chamber, an occurrence without precedent in the State's legislative history. The ceremony was marked by the chief minister himself sounding the ritual hand bell, while sounds from a conch shell shattered the Assembly air. "The Assembly is temple of democracy," CM said.

Mumbai Youth Congress protests over NEET paper leak, seeks JPC probe

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Youth Congress workers on Wednesday staged a protest in south Mumbai against the alleged leak of the National Eligibility Cum Entrance Test (NEET) question paper and demanded a Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC) probe into the issue. The protest was held outside the state CET Cell office in Fort area under the leadership of Mumbai Youth Congress president Zeenat Shabreen. The protesters raised slogans against the BJP-led Central Government. Shabreen alleged that the paper leak has jeopardised the future of nearly 2.4 million students and shattered the aspirations of their parents. She said Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan should resign immediately on moral grounds, and students affected by the alleged irregularities should be



compensated. Shabreen also called for the constitution of a JPC to conduct a detailed investigation into the matter. She also alleged that the former Director General of the National Testing Agency (NTA), during whose tenure the 2024 NEET paper leak allegedly took place, was subsequently appointed as the principal adviser to the Chief Minister of Chhattisgarh. Police detained several Youth Congress office-bearers and workers who participated in the demonstration, the organisers said. The NEET (UG) 2026 exam for admission to undergraduate courses in medical colleges, held on May 3, was cancelled on Tuesday amid allegations of paper leak. The Government asked the CBI to carry out a comprehensive inquiry into the "irregularities".

AIADMK rebel MLAs removed from party posts

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami on Wednesday removed leaders, including SP Velumani, C Ve Shanmugam and C Vijayabaskar, from their party posts. The party chief cracked the whip on the rebel MLAs, including Natham R



Edappadi K Palaniswami

Viswanathan, after they defied the party's diktat and voted in favour of the TVK Government during the confidence motion in the Assembly earlier in the day. Palaniswami replaced the party posts of the 25 MLAs and appointed new district secretaries in their places.

Khera appears before Assam Police over claims against CM’s wife

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

Congress leader Pawan Khera appeared before the Assam Police Crime Branch on Wednesday for questioning in connection with cases filed by Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma’s wife, Riniki Bhuyan Sharma.

The cases were lodged after Khera alleged that Sharma possessed multiple passports and undisclosed properties abroad.

Speaking to reporters before entering the Crime Branch office, Khera said he was cooperating with the investigation.

“I have been summoned by the police and have come accordingly. We respect the law and the judiciary, so I am



here as per legal procedure,” he said. Khera said he would speak to the press in detail after the questioning was completed. Sharma had filed criminal complaints against Khera and others at the Guwahati Crime Branch

Police Station under various provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS).

The charges against the Congress leader include making false statements in connection with an election, cheating, forgery, use of

forged documents as genuine, intentional insult with intent to provoke breach of peace, and defamation.

Earlier, Assam Police had visited Khera’s residence in Delhi, but he was reportedly not present there.

Khera had initially approached the Telangana High Court, which granted him seven-day transit anticipatory bail. However, Assam Police challenged the order in the Supreme Court. The apex court granted him anticipatory bail, observing that the matter appeared to have arisen out of political rivalry.

Pawan Khera left the police station at 10 pm after 12 hours. He has been asked to appear again on Thursday morning.

Law will take its own course in Khera case : Himanta

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Wednesday said that the law will take its own course in the case filed by his wife against Congress leader Pawan Khera for alleging that she possessed multiple passports and undisclosed properties abroad.

As per the Supreme Court order, he (Khera) appeared before the Crime Branch on Wednesday, and the police will definitely ask him questions, the chief minister said at a press conference here after chairing the first Cabinet meeting of his second term in office.

“The law will take its own course, but we have already received in writing from the Union Government that the documents Khera displayed were fake,” he



said. Police investigations, therefore, will not take long, and they will be able to submit the chargesheet within the stipulated time, the CM said.

“If he continues to cooperate, the submission of the chargesheet or final report

will be faster, but if he does not, it may take time.

We want to conclude the case as soon as possible,” Sarma added.

Khera came to the Crime Branch office here earlier in the day and said he was cooperating with the

investigation. “I have been summoned by the police and have come accordingly. We respect the law and the judiciary, so I am here as per legal procedure,” he said.

Khera said he would speak to the press in detail after the questioning was completed.

The chief minister’s wife had filed criminal complaints against Khera and others at the Guwahati Crime Branch Police Station under various provisions of the *Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita* (BNS).

The charges against the Congress leader include making false statements in connection with an election, cheating, forgery, use of forged documents as genuine, intentional insult with intent to provoke breach of peace, and defamation.

J&K Police nab two terror sympathisers in Kishtwar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Continuing its crackdown against the terrorist ecosystem sustaining active foreign terrorists, Jammu and Kashmir Police have so far arrested two terrorist sympathisers, allegedly behind providing logistics support at a hideout in the Singhpora area of Chhatroo in the Kishtwar district of Jammu division.

According to a press statement issued by the office of District Police, Kishtwar, “in a decisive operation against anti-national elements, Jammu and Kashmir Police have arrested a key accused linked to providing aid to foreign terrorists at a hideout in Singhpora, Chatroo,

Kishtwar”. The case was registered under FIR number 03/2026 at Police Station Chatroo, invoking Sections 61(2), 109, 147, 148 of BNS; Sections 13, 16, 18, 19, 20 of UAPA; and Section 7/27 of the Arms Act.

According to Senior Superintendent of Police, Kishtwar Naresh Singh, J&K police apprehended Mashkoor Ahmed S/o Mohd Ramzan, resident of Beighpora, Singhpora, Kishtwar, a teacher in the School Education Department, who was directly implicated in facilitating the terrorists’ hideout.

SSP noted that by arresting the terrorist sympathiser, the police have exposed the local ecosystem extending logistics to terrorists in the region.



“This arrest disrupts critical logistics supporting terror activities in the region”, Singh added. Earlier, Maneer Ahmed, a resident of Bandeyan Naidgam, was also arrested for similar offences

by the Kishtwar police team.

Police said further investigation is underway to detect and dismantle the wider network involved in supporting terrorist activities in the district.

On February 22 this year, three terrorists, including one of the top commanders of the Pakistan-based Jaish-e-Mohammad (JeM) terrorist outfit, were neutralised by the joint team of security forces in the general area of Passerkut in Chhatroo, Kishtwar district.

The terrorist commander was later identified as a Jaish-e-Mohammad commander, Saifullah.

According to security forces, Saifullah had reportedly infiltrated into Jammu and Kashmir nearly five years ago and remained active in the region, allegedly masterminding several deadly attacks on security forces, including the one in July 2024 that left four soldiers, including a captain, dead.

Andhra minister welcomes kharif MSP hike, thanks Union Govt

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Amaravati

Andhra Pradesh Agriculture Minister K Atchannaidu on Wednesday welcomed the Centre’s decision to increase MSP for Kharif crops for the 2026-27 marketing season, saying that the move would strengthen farmers financially and reinforce confidence in the agriculture sector.

The Centre approved a massive expenditure of ₹2.6 lakh crore towards increasing Minimum Support Price (MSP) for Kharif crops, and it reflected the Government’s sincerity and commitment towards safeguarding farmers’ interests and ensuring remunerative prices for agricultural



Andhra Pradesh Agriculture Minister K Atchannaidu

produce, Atchannaidu said in a press release.

“The Centre’s decision to increase MSP for Kharif crops for the 2026-27 marketing season will strengthen farmers financially and further

boost confidence in the agriculture sector,” he added.

He observed that fixing MSPs by ensuring at least 50 per cent profit over the cost of cultivation provided real assurance to farmers and

noted that MSPs of several crops have been significantly increased to ensure fair returns for farmers’ hard work. The minister said that the MSP of common paddy has been increased by ₹72 per quintal to ₹2,441, while the MSP for Grade-A paddy has been fixed at ₹2,461, which he said would greatly benefit paddy farmers.

He further noted that the MSPs have been fixed at ₹4,073 for jowar, ₹5,205 for ragi, ₹2,900 for bajra, ₹8,200 for horse gram, ₹2,410 for maize, Rs 10,346 for sesame, ₹8,343 for sunflower, ₹8,667 for cotton and ₹7,517 for groundnut.

Atchannaidu opined that the decision comes at a time when the agriculture sector

was facing increasing expenditure on fertilisers, seeds and labour. He praised the Central Government for moving forward with the view that farmers’ welfare forms the foundation for the country’s development and reiterated that protecting farmers’ interests remains a priority for both the Centre and the State Government.

The minister clarified that the Andhra Pradesh Government would take all necessary measures to ensure that farmers in the state fully receive the MSP benefits announced by the Centre through effective procurement centres, marketing systems and implementation mechanisms.

TVK Govt will function with horse speed, says CM Vijay

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Wednesday said his Government will function with the speed of a horse delivering clean administration.

He assured that his administration would rigorously protect the rights of minorities, women, children, youth, farmers, and Government workers. His Government will be committed to secularism, social justice, transparency, and involved in public welfare. Speaking during the debate on the confidence motion, which he moved as mandated by



Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar, in the Assembly, Vijay remarked that his Government would work with “horse speed” and deliver development rather than indulge in backroom political deals.

His remark comes amidst a charge by Leader of the Opposition Udhayanidhi Stalin, and AIADMK leader

Edappadi K Palaniswami on alleged “horse-trading” in the wake of lone AMMK MLA S Kamaraj and AIADMK faction comprising 25 legislators announcing support to TVK Government in the Assembly.

“This Government is one that functions with the speed of a horse and not one that indulges in horse-trading,” Vijay said, adding development will be dispensed at full throttle.

DMDK leader Premalatha Vijayakanth also accused the newly formed TVK Government of “unethical” political manoeuvring to secure a majority in the House.



US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor during his visit to Missionaries of Charity in Kolkata

PTI

Kin of Ahmedabad plane crash victims seek black box data

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ahmedabad

The family members of Ahmedabad plane crash victims on Wednesday vehemently demanded access to the aircraft’s black box data to know what exactly happened in the final moments.

They said although 11 months have passed since the tragedy struck, they still do not know the reasons that led to the crash.

A total of 260 persons were killed after an Air India flight AI 171, a Boeing 787-8 aircraft en route to London Gatwick, crashed into a medical hostel complex shortly after it took off from Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel International Airport in Ahmedabad on June 12, 2025.

A few family members held a meeting in Ahmedabad on Wednesday to discuss their concerns and demands.

Kaviraj Kuldip Ishrani, a

convenor for the aggrieved families’ law firm, said the families have been seeking access to the raw data from the Flight Data Recorder (FDR) and Cockpit Voice Recorder (CVR).

“Eleven months have passed since the horrific crash of AI 171 in Ahmedabad. The families have been demanding raw data of the FDR and the CVR. Several families have also been in touch with Federation of Indian Pilots (FIP) president CS Randhawa, who had written to the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) India and AAIB UK,” he said.

The families demand that the UK AAIB take a more active role in the investigation, and request raw data and probe material from AAIB India. Ishrani said they want investigators to examine whether the Ram Air Turbine (RAT) was deployed on the ground.



Wreckage of the Air India plane that crashed moments after taking off from the Ahmedabad airport, lies on a building in Ahmedabad

Palaniswami has right to appoint whip: AIADMK MLA

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

AIADMK chief Edappadi K Palaniswami has the right to appoint a whip for the Assembly, said MLA Thalavai Sundaram on Wednesday.

His remarks came hours after rebel AIADMK leaders, led by MLAs C Ve Shanmugam and SP Velumani, asked Palaniswami to show a copy of the resolution of the meeting held to elect the whip.

As per the tenth schedule of the Constitution, Palaniswami has the right to appoint a whip, Sundaram

said and showed a Constitution document for reference, while speaking to reporters.

“Just go through it,” he said, and added that it provides the provision to appoint a whip by the party leader.

The split in the AIADMK came into the open during the trust vote proceedings as the faction of 25 MLAs led by party leaders Velumani-Shanmugam voted in favour of the Vijay-led Government.

The AIADMK won 47 seats in the recently held Assembly elections.

Sundaram claimed that



the anti-defection law will apply against the rebel AIADMK MLAs.

AIADMK leader and advocate IS Inabudurai said a complaint letter has been given to the Speaker to disqualify the rebel party MLAs, who voted for TVK during the floor test.

“Though the Speaker was not available to receive the complaint, we have given it to the Assembly secretary, who promised to pass it to the Speaker,” told reporters.

Palaniswami earlier in the day claimed that as general secretary of the party, he

had the right to appoint the whip. The whip, Agri SS Krishnamurthy, had informed all the MLAs through SMS, e-mail and registered post that the party will vote against the Government in the floor test, he claimed.

Asked if he would seek legal action against those who did not vote by the party’s diktat, he said, “Wait and watch.”

The cross-voting by 25 AIADMK rebel MLAs on Wednesday caused the TVK Government to significantly improve its tally to 144 in the Assembly.



Editor's
TAKE

The AI gold rush and the jobs paradox

There is a mad rush towards AI learning, but will this craze actually create jobs or is the society prepared for disruptions AI may bring, is the big question

No technology in recent times has created a frenzy like AI. When AI exploded into the mainstream, it was welcomed with open arms because the promise it holds is immense. From healthcare to industry, from space exploration to defence – AI is a game-changer. But it has its downside too. Many professions are going to undergo an overhaul, and many people will lose their jobs. Estimates suggest AI could displace 92 million jobs globally by 2030, with up to 300 million jobs worldwide affected by automation. However, the situation may not be as grim as the figures suggest, as AI may also create jobs. People with AI skill sets will not only find employment but may also be better off. And that is the paradox of our times.

The very technology that is going to consume jobs is also going to create new opportunities. This contradiction is stark in our country, where unemployment is already high. Thanks to confusion and aggressive marketing, there is a great frenzy to learn AI skills – students, professionals, and even schoolchildren are rushing to enrol in AI courses in the hope of securing their future. AI has become the new career mantra. Platforms offering AI certifications, prompt engineering lessons, boot camps, and Generative AI modules are witnessing unprecedented demand. The fear of being left behind has created this mad rush to learn AI. The anxiety is understandable. Routine jobs are especially vulnerable. Entry-level white-collar roles may shrink significantly in the coming decade. It is like history repeating itself, when industrial innovations left workers jobless or when the introduction of computers led to job losses.

Yet, AI is not merely destroying jobs; it is reshaping them. Companies are increasingly looking for workers who can manage AI tools. The future may belong to professionals who combine domain expertise with AI literacy – finance plus AI, law plus AI, healthcare plus AI, and so on. This explains the extraordinary rush towards AI learning.

But there is also a danger of illusion. The booming AI education market has created thousands of courses promising instant expertise and guaranteed jobs. Many are superficial, outdated, or designed more for commercial profit than genuine skill-building. A certificate alone will not ensure employability. The real gap lies between learning AI theoretically and applying it meaningfully in real-world situations. There are other speed breakers as well. India still faces serious digital inequality. Educational institutions often struggle to update curricula quickly enough for a technology evolving almost every day. Moreover, ethical and regulatory concerns around privacy, misinformation, and bias remain unresolved. Governments, too, are yet to fully prepare for the social disruptions caused by AI. The market will eventually separate serious learning from certificate chasing. Employers will reward adaptability, creativity, and problem-solving, not merely familiarity with AI. AI literacy is not the same as job preparedness. AI can improve productivity and create opportunities, but it may also widen inequality. The real challenge is building a workforce that can think critically, adapt continuously, and combine human intelligence with artificial intelligence.

The unravelling of Dravidian order

Vijay has emerged as the face of generational anger and anti-establishment politics. But his rise also highlights a political vacuum: the old Dravidian order is losing credibility, while the new alternative remains inexperienced and organisationally weak



NILANTHA
ILANGAMUWA

Joseph Vijay Chandrasekhar, celebrated for decades as “Thalapathy” – the commander – is now confronting a truth far harsher than cinematic fiction: Tamil Nadu is not a theatre waiting for a hero’s entrance. It is among India’s most politically self-aware states, shaped by decades of ideological struggle, linguistic pride, welfare politics, caste negotiation, and a deeply emotional contract with social justice. Vijay may have conquered the electoral imagination, but the machinery of governance is proving far more unforgiving than fan adulation.

Tamil Nadu today stands at a historic crossroads. The Dravidian order that dominated the state for nearly sixty years is weakening, yet no alternative has fully established legitimacy. The DMK retains organisational strength and administrative continuity, while the AIADMK still survives through welfare-era loyalties and caste-based networks. But both parties increasingly appear ideologically exhausted. Their rhetoric continues to invoke social justice, federalism, and Tamil identity, yet their politics often resemble bureaucratic management rather than transformative mobilisation. Vijay’s rise emerged precisely from this vacuum.

National commentary has often caricatured Tamil Nadu as a state addicted to “cinema politics”, but that interpretation misses the deeper historical reality. MG Ramachandran and J Jayalalithaa succeeded not merely because they were film stars, but because they embedded themselves within the emotional and ideological framework created by the Dravidian movement. In Tamil Nadu, cinema became political pedagogy. Film dialogues carried ideological messages. Stardom mattered only when it resonated with the anxieties and aspirations of workers, backward castes, the poor, and Tamil linguistic identity. The foundations of this politics were laid by EV Ramasamy, whose Self-Respect Movement challenged Brahminical dominance in education, administration, and ritual hierarchy. His attack on caste oppression transformed Tamil politics permanently.

Later, CN Annadurai converted radical social critique into electoral politics through the DMK. The movement shifted political discourse away from elite nationalism towards dignity, representation, and linguistic self-respect. Tamil politics became inseparable from the question of social mobility. This ideological inheritance helped create one of India’s most paradoxical yet successful states. Tamil Nadu remained fiercely regional while becoming deeply integrated into global manufacturing networks. Tamil Nadu built one of India’s most effective



VIJAY’S RISE IS NEITHER ACCIDENTAL NOR MIRACULOUS. IT REFLECTS THE IDEOLOGICAL VACUUM THAT EMERGES WHEN SUCCESSFUL SOCIETIES OUTGROW THEIR OLD SLOGANS WITHOUT DISCOVERING A NEW POLITICAL LANGUAGE. VOTERS REJECTED STAGNATION WITHOUT FULLY TRUSTING DISRUPTION

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welfare systems. Midday meal schemes pioneered under K. Kamaraj and expanded under MG Ramachandran reshaped nutrition and school attendance. Public healthcare, subsidised food distribution, maternal health programmes, and women-centric welfare schemes produced social indicators that consistently outperform much of the country.

M Karunanidhi, a scriptwriter, ideologue, and political tactician, fused literary performance, welfare governance, and coalition negotiation into a durable political machine. His son, MK Stalin, inherited not just a party but an institutional ecosystem. Under Stalin, Tamil Nadu retained economic growth despite post-pandemic pressures. Welfare delivery expanded through programmes such as doorstep healthcare initiatives, while the state sharpened its resistance to centralisation on issues like NEET, language policy, and fiscal devolution.

Yet the DMK’s central challenge was not administrative failure. It was emotional fatigue. Younger voters inherited the welfare state without inheriting the historical memory that once legitimised Dravidian politics. Anti-Brahmin rhetoric no longer electrifies an aspirational generation working in IT corridors or navigating precarious urban employment. Into this opening stepped Vijay.

Unlike Kamal Haasan, who entered politics through technocratic idealism, Vijay projected emotional populism. He did not initially offer a fully coherent ideological programme. Instead, he offered rupture - a symbolic rebellion against dynastic politics, corruption fatigue, and political stagnation. His appeal rested on accessibility and generational impatience. Importantly, he avoided overt alignment with Hindutva while softening the rigid atheistic tone historically associated with Dravidian discourse. This ambiguity broadened his social appeal.

But electoral momentum and governing capacity are entirely different realities. Cinema rewards singular charisma; parliamentary democracy rewards negotiation, compromise, organisational discipline, and patience. Vijay’s transition from celebrity icon to political admin-

istrator has exposed the limitations of charisma-driven mobilisation. Triumphalist rhetoric, strategic inconsistency, and the inexperience of advisers intoxicated by spectacle have complicated his emergence as a credible governing force.

The deeper anxiety within Tamil Nadu’s political establishment reflects fear of displacement. Reports of tactical accommodation between the DMK and AIADMK - once unimaginable rivals – indicate how survival instincts are overtaking ideological hostility.

This crisis has also exposed the transactional nature of alliance politics. Congress leaders who survived electorally through DMK support now flirt with Vijay’s camp in search of future relevance. Alliances increasingly resemble temporary survival arrangements rather than ideological partnerships. Meanwhile, the BJP continues to struggle electorally in Tamil Nadu because Hindutva’s North Indian cultural grammar encounters resistance in a state where linguistic identity historically superseded pan-Hindu consolidation.

Yet Delhi’s influence no longer depends entirely on electoral dominance. Governors, investigative agencies, and coalition engineering increasingly function as instruments of political leverage. Across Tamil Nadu, suspicion persists that constitutional ambiguity may be used to shape outcomes from behind the scenes. The contradiction confronting Tamil Nadu is therefore profound. Economically, it remains one of India’s most advanced states. Socially, it

continues to outperform much of the country in education, healthcare, and women’s participation. Politically, however, it has entered an era where no force commands complete moral authority. The old Dravidian order no longer inspires unquestioned loyalty, while the new populist alternative has not yet demonstrated governing maturity.

Vijay’s rise is neither accidental nor miraculous. It reflects the ideological vacuum that emerges when successful societies outgrow their old slogans without discovering a new political language. Voters rejected stagnation without fully trusting disruption.

The danger now is that Tamil Nadu may drift towards personality-driven politics detached from doctrinal seriousness. If the DMK and AIADMK unite merely to block Vijay, they may postpone collapse while accelerating their irrelevance. The state may discover that charisma alone cannot govern industrial growth, fiscal pressures, caste tensions, and federal confrontation simultaneously. Tamil Nadu’s political story is about the uncertain transition from a deeply ideological republic to a more fragmented and emotionally volatile political order. The Dravidian system that once reshaped Indian federalism is no longer secure. It is improvising in real time, searching for a new language of legitimacy in a state that refuses to stand still.

PIC TALK



Tourists participate in river rafting in the Beas River during the summer season in Manali, Kullu.

PHOTO: PTI

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REPEATED NEET FAILURES SHAKE STUDENTS' TRUST IN NTA

The cancellation of the NEET-UG examination has once again exposed serious flaws in the functioning of the National Testing Agency (NTA). Established in 2017 to conduct major entrance examinations in a transparent and efficient manner, the agency has repeatedly faced controversies involving paper leaks, technical failures, poor exam management, and irregularities in evaluation.

The latest NEET-UG cancellation, triggered by allegations of a paper leak, has affected nearly 22.79 lakh students. For lakhs of aspirants who spent years preparing with sincerity and discipline, the decision has brought anxiety, uncertainty, and emotional distress. Similar controversies emerged in 2024, when allegations regarding grace

marks and paper leaks led to nationwide protests and legal disputes. The cancellation of UGC-NET in the same year further weakened public confidence in the agency.

Frequent irregularities not only damage the credibility of the NTA but also undermine the integrity of India’s education system. Students deserve a fair, secure, and reliable examination process. The government must ensure strict accountability, stronger cybersecurity, better coordination at examination centres, and severe punishment for those involved in leaks or negligence.

After nearly a decade of experience, the NTA can no longer afford repeated failures. Restoring students’ trust must now become its highest priority.

AMRIT LAL MARU 'RAVI' | INDORE

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

The human side of AI in the classroom



RITU
JAVA

2ND OPINION

Artificial intelligence is no longer confined to the edges of innovation; it is steadily becoming part of the everyday rhythm of education. Its presence in school curricula is not loud or disruptive, but quietly influential, shaping how students engage with learning and how educators respond to their needs.

Not only are we seeing new tools; we are also seeing an entirely different learning experience emerging through this evolution. The advent of AI has opened up ways to support not only students’ academic growth, but also the confidence and well-being that sit at the heart of meaningful learning.

For years, the classroom has been built on a straightforward approach - one teacher, one lesson, one pace. But all learners are different; some move ahead quickly,

while others need more time.

AI is starting to close this gap by identifying when a student is struggling or is ready to move on, allowing learning to adapt to each individual’s needs. It also changes the role of teachers by taking over tasks such as grading and tracking progress.

As classrooms evolve, teachers are becoming guides and mentors who help students interpret material rather than simply instruct them. At the same time, learning remains deeply tied to confidence, motivation, and self-worth. In this context, AI can contribute positively to the system. If implemented correctly, it can support learning through timely feedback, personalised instruction, and early detection of disengagement, among other methods. It can support both performance and well-being.

Nonetheless, the story has another side. The fear is that students will turn to AI and thoughtlessly use it as a shortcut — skipping the thinking and questioning that lead to genuine learning. Therefore, schools should teach students how to use AI responsibly rather than simply how to access it, with the goal of developing critical thinkers rather than merely efficient problem-solvers.

Then there are ethical questions, which are becoming increasingly important.

How is student data being used?

Are these systems fair to all learners?

Are we teaching children how to use technology responsibly?

These are not technical questions alone; they are deeply human ones. And they must be part of the conversation in every school that chooses to embrace AI.

The real impact lies in how thoughtfully schools integrate AI. The priority should be on building AI literacy rather than simply teaching its usage, while ensuring that teachers are equipped and trained alongside students.

Education has never been just about facts. At its heart, education is an experience rooted in relationships and mentorship. AI cannot replace that, and it should not try to. What it can do is strengthen it.

When AI is used thoughtfully in the classroom, it can make learning spaces more flexible and welcoming for all students, recognising and embracing the different experiences of each learner. It gives teachers more time to help students become more curious, confident, and expressive. Perhaps this is the real power of AI in the classroom: making education truly inclusive for everyone.

The writer is the Principal of Dharav High School, Gurugram

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Leaders must practise austerity first

Refer to your news regarding the Prime Minister’s call to adopt a patriotic lifestyle centred on economic self-reliance and austerity.

The disparity between the government’s call for public austerity and the continued extravagance of our leadership is a glaring democratic injustice. Following the 2024 Budget, it is hypocritical to ask the common man to tighten his belt while lavish official expenditure and foreign tours remain unchecked. Directives to avoid gold purchases or cancel travel do more than stifle personal freedom; they threaten the livelihoods of millions employed in the tourism and jewellery sectors, who are already reeling from economic instability.

Credibility in governance is earned through example, not edict. It is fundamentally unjust to slash subsidies for the poor while spending crores on state events. Furthermore, the rhetoric regarding foreign spending misses the point. Reserve Bank of India data confirms that the real driver of dollar outflows is not the casual traveller or middle-class weddings, but high-net-worth individuals investing in foreign assets.

If the administration wishes the public to embrace simplicity, it must first curb its own extravagance.

S PADMANABHAN | KOCHI

Need for collective economic restraint

Fiscal prudence and appeals for restraint are often mocked today as the tail wagging the dog, yet history shows that national sacrifice during difficult periods can strengthen long-term resilience. Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s appeal for reduced imports and mindful consumption recalls Lal Bahadur Shastri’s call in the 1960s for citizens to voluntarily fast from grains once a week when India was living in a humiliating “ship-to-mouth” condition before the Green Revolution transformed food security.

Such collective discipline remains relevant even today. India’s appetite for imported gold, luxury consumption, and speculative land accumulation weakens the broader economy. Ironically, Pliny once lamented that Rome’s gold flowed into India through trade. Today, the reverse is occurring as precious foreign exchange is drained to satisfy an unproductive obsession with gold.

Likewise, excessive land hoarding has turned housing from a social necessity into a speculative commodity. Economic progress requires not only government policy, but also civic restraint, productive investment, and a culture that values national resilience over conspicuous accumulation.

HARSH PAWARIA | ROHTAK

NEET leaks raise serious concerns

The cancellation of the May 2026 NEET-UG examination following allegations of a paper leak has once again exposed the fragile credibility of India’s entrance examination system.

NEET is the single gateway for admission to MBBS and BDS courses across the country, with nearly 24 lakh students appearing every year. When one examination determines the future of aspiring doctors, repeated irregularities become deeply alarming.

Major controversies surrounding NEET have surfaced repeatedly in 2016, 2021, 2023, 2024, and now in 2026. Such serial lapses compel many to question whether the system has become a farce. The latest cancellation is a serious black mark on the country’s educational framework. Investigative agencies, including the Rajasthan Special Operations Group, reportedly found evidence that the examination paper had been leaked before the test. The government has now handed the matter over to the CBI for a nationwide probe. While candidates will not need to re-register or pay additional fees, the emotional stress and uncertainty faced by students remain immense.

The authorities must ensure transparency, accountability, and stronger safeguards to restore public trust.

CK SUBRAMANIAM | NAVI MUMBAI

Urgent reforms needed in CGHS: Air India retirees trapped in a bureaucratic nightmare

Thousands of retired Air India employees are today trapped in a distressing cycle of humiliation and medical insecurity under the Central Government Health Scheme (CGHS). For them, what was meant to be a dependable healthcare safeguard has instead turned into a nightmare of delayed reimbursements, and administrative apathy



VK BAHUGUNA

As India pushes towards universal health coverage under Ayushman Bharat, which is one of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's greatest gifts to the people, another flagship welfare scheme — the Central Government Health Scheme (CGHS) — is failing thousands of its most vulnerable beneficiaries. Senior citizens who

served the national carrier, Air India, for decades are now caught in a web of red tape, delayed payments, and hospital harassment that has turned a promised seamless medical safety net into a source of constant anxiety and financial distress, and nobody bothers if one complains.

Following the 2022 privatisation of Air India to the Tata Group, the Government of India rightly extended CGHS benefits to eligible retired and retiring employees as a social safeguard. Official memoranda assured cashless treatment, medicines, and investigations at empanelled hospitals — benefits meant to replace or improve the earlier Retired Employees Medical Scheme (REMS). Yet, on the ground, the reality is starkly different.

Many of these pensioners, now in their 70s and 80s, are forced to pay huge sums upfront for treatment and then chase reimbursements for months, often receiving only partial settlements or rejected claims. The root of much of this suffering is an unnecessary detour through the callous and arrogantly incompetent UTI Infrastructure Technology and Services Limited (UTIITSL), which has been appointed as the Bill Clearing Agency (BCA) for Air India-related CGHS claims. Instead of routing everything through the efficient National Health Authority (NHA) system that handles the main CGHS operations, these beneficiaries have been shunted into a parallel, slower track.

A glaring example is Indresh Hospital in Dehradun, which has been harassed for the last two months by UTIITSL. Despite submitting its valid NABH accreditation certificate six times, UTIITSL continues to reject claims and refuses to recognise the accreditation. Even a formal complaint lodged on the PMO grievance portal was dismissed contemptuously, further eroding trust in the system. This has forced the hospital either to demand full cash payments from Air India retirees or to turn them away, directly impacting patients in Uttarakhand and surrounding areas.

The Additional Director, CGHS, is not authorised to supervise these matters and, even after his communication, UTIITSL does not bother. Hospitals all over India — from Delhi to Mumbai to Chennai — empanelled under CGHS report similar harassment: bills are rejected on minor technical grounds, accreditation certificates are questioned despite NABH compliance, and payments are delayed for 8 to 18 months. This has led several hospitals either to refuse cashless services to Air India cardholders or to demand full payment in advance.

One affected retiree from Delhi described the ordeal: "We served the nation's airline through its toughest times. Now, in old age, we stand outside hospital counters begging for basic dignity in healthcare."

Similar stories echo across Mumbai, Kolkata, Chennai, and smaller cities where Air India staff settled after retirement. In many Tier-2 locations, empanelled facilities are scarce, and those available are increasingly reluctant due to the UTIITSL bottleneck.

Systemic Failures Plaguing CGHS
The problems extend far beyond Air India beneficiaries. CGHS serves over 45 lakh central government employees, pensioners, and dependants, yet it grapples with outdated infrastructure and processes. Hospital empanelment remains inadequate, especially outside metropolitan areas. CGHS package rates for surgeries and procedures have not kept pace with inflation or private-sector costs, prompting many reputed hospitals either to opt out or to deliver compromised care to CGHS patients.

Claim settlements are notoriously slow. Digital portals exist but are not fully user-friendly, forcing many elderly beneficiaries to submit physical documents and face repeated queries over formatting or missing stamps. Advanced treatments often face caps or outright exclusions, leaving patients to bridge the gap from their meagre pensions.

For Air India retirees specifically, the situation is aggravated by card-related confusion. Many received yellow-



strip cards meant for autonomous bodies instead of the promised special-category cards. Entitlements are not clearly printed, leading to disputes at hospital counters. While OPD services through CGHS wellness centres work somewhat smoothly, inpatient department (IPD), day-care procedures, diagnostics, and emergency care have been severely affected by the UTIITSL routing.

This detour appears to contradict the directives that envisioned seamless NHA integration. The result is a classic case of policy intent being defeated by poor execution. Hospitals, already operating on thin margins under CGHS rates, are now bearing the brunt of endless back-and-forth with UTIITSL, leading them either to turn away patients or to insist on cash payments.

Families are selling assets or borrowing money to fund treatment while waiting for reimbursements that may never come in full. It raises serious questions about the government's commitment to welfare for disinvested public-sector employees. If the CGHS scheme — with a dedicated budget — cannot deliver basic cashless care efficiently, how can India scale more ambitious health programmes?

Due to mounting frustration, petitions have reached various High Courts, including notices issued by the Madras High Court on related matters. Retirees' associations have repeatedly written to the Ministries of Health, Civil Aviation, and Finance, highlighting violations of earlier assurances.

CGHS requires bold, time-bound action rather than incremental tweaks. The most immediate step must be the removal of the UTIITSL detour for all Air India beneficiaries, who should be fully integrated into the NHA platform. NHA's experience with large-scale digital processing under PMJAY can deliver settlements within 30-45 days, restore hospital confidence, and enable genuine cashless treatment.

Second, CGHS rates must be revised annually through a transparent medical inflation index linked to NABH standards, and coverage should include modern therapies without arbitrary caps. Empanelment drives should target at least 1,000 additional hospitals in Tier-2 and Tier-3 cities.

Third, complete digital transformation is overdue. Auto-approval for high-compliance claims and penalties on clearing agencies for delays beyond 60 days would enforce accountability.

Fourth, all retirees should receive standardised CGHS cards with lifelong validity.

Finally, the government should consider a dedicated medical corpus for these beneficiaries and explore convergence with other schemes for hybrid coverage.

CGHS was envisioned as a model of dignified healthcare for public servants. Today, it risks becoming a symbol of bureaucratic indifference. The suffering of Air India retirees, exemplified by cases like Indresh Hospital in Dehradun, and the broader challenges within the scheme deserve national attention.

The media, civil society, and policymakers must push for reforms that place patients — especially senior citizens — at the centre. The government must act decisively to repair CGHS before more lives are compromised by avoidable administrative hurdles.

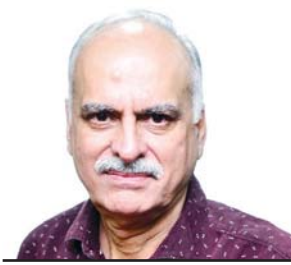
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Assam polls reveal India's hardening electoral politics



ANIL ANAND

High-intensity poll-eve rows, particularly involving corruption and sleaze allegations, are a known phenomenon in Indian electoral history. This has become more pronounced during the last decade, with even top leaders indulging in no-holds-barred personalised attacks, and allegations of corruption at high places becoming a familiar theme.

However, by and large, this has been a one-way traffic, with the ruling BJP-led National Democratic Alliance having the upper hand. The strategy of treating political rivals as enemies — also a relatively new concept in over seven decades of the country's democratic history — and fixing them using the might of statecraft, squarely to win elections, has become increasingly visible. By hook or by crook. This one-way traffic ran smoothly and effectively for the ruling dispensation until Pawan Khera, Chairman, Media & Publicity (Communication Department), AICC, broke the monotony with a set of serious corruption allegations targeting Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma and his wife.

As Khera chose an opportune moment — two days before campaigning for the Assembly elections was to end — to target Sarma, it naturally created a furore, with the latter baying for the former's blood and turning vituperative not only against Khera, but also the octogenarian Congress president, Mallikarjun Kharge, and Rahul Gandhi.

Ironically, at the state level, it is a showdown between two contrasting political models that have been at play on the national political horizon since 2014. The lineup has been "Hurricane Strategist vs Guarded Challenger", represented by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, with Kharge repeatedly getting trapped in the crossfire.

A true reflection of this model came to the fore in the form of a duel between Sarma and Gaurav Gogoi — the incumbent Chief Minister spearheading the BJP campaign, and the Congress's CM hopeful. Khera's tirade against Sarma has not only taken the confrontation to the next level, with the only difference being that the Congress, instead of the BJP, was the "instigator" and the BJP the target this time around.

As Sarma frothed with anger after his no-holds-barred model — a replica of the BJP's national template — was jolted by an opponent trying to beat him at his own game, his frustration was visible when he burst into expletives targeting Kharge and Gandhi, apart from Khera.

Notwithstanding the fact that the reins of power during elections rest with the Election Commission of India, CM Sarma's public outbursts resulted in the Assam Police losing no time in landing at Khera's doorstep in Delhi, acting swiftly on an FIR filed overnight by Sarma's wife.

What did he say about Kharge? "Kaun hai Kharge? Pagal hai woh..."

What did he say about Khera while implicitly targeting Gandhi? Khera would spend his "last moments" in an Assam jail, as he declared the allegations against him and his wife to be "fabricated". "I would file a case against Khera first, then turn the others into 'peda' (sweets)," a remark ostensibly directed at Gandhi.

The backdrop to this conflict was Khera's allegations, levelled at a press conference at the AICC headquarters in Delhi, that Sarma's wife, Riniki Bhuyan Sarma, "holds multiple foreign passports and undisclosed overseas assets". The genesis of Khera's allegations lies in similar charges levelled earlier by Sarma against Gogoi, alleging his wife's "Pakistan links".

Interestingly, Sarma, a former Congressman, was once the blue-eyed boy of former Chief Minister Tarun Gogoi and a senior minister in his Cabinet before joining the BJP, after Gandhi had reportedly refused to entertain his claim to the Chief Minister's chair. Of course, Gaurav Gogoi is Tarun Gogoi's son.

Gaurav Gogoi, educated abroad, has gradually evolved into a mature politician and impressive parliamentarian before being appointed Assam Congress chief ahead of the Assembly elections. Unlike Himanta Biswa Sarma's aggressive political style, Gogoi has maintained a calm and calculated approach while carrying forward his father Tarun Gogoi's legacy.

He strengthened his position politically after winning the Jorhat Lok Sabha seat despite strong BJP opposition and Sarma's towering presence in Assam politics. The victory boosted Gogoi's confidence and established him as a serious challenger with Rahul Gandhi's backing.

How will these contrasting political models of rivalry manifest in the ongoing Assembly elections in Assam?

Surely, the stakes are much higher this time for both the BJP and the Congress than they were in the Lok Sabha polls. Assam has been the BJP's gateway to the North-East region, where it once had virtually no presence and where Sarma played an important role after defecting from the Congress, leading eventually to the fulfilment of his chief ministerial ambitions. It is equally important for both the BJP and Sarma that the party returns to power in order to retain its grip over the region, especially with an eye on the 2029 Lok Sabha elections.

Even at a personal level, Sarma has far more at stake this time than ever before. Leading the BJP to victory will not only help him retain the chief ministership but also add to his political clout. A defeat — that too at the hands of the Rahul Gandhi-Gaurav Gogoi combine, who have long been his principal targets — would considerably weaken his political standing and could raise serious questions about his future.

The Congress, meanwhile, has an opportunity to stage a comeback in its former citadel of North-Eastern India. A victory in Assam, the largest state in the region, would provide a significant boost to the party, which has been pushed into political oblivion in the area by the BJP, with Sarma playing a stellar role in settling scores with his erstwhile party and Gandhi.

A Congress victory under Gogoi, in the absence of his father, would be a major boost both for him personally and for the party. For Gogoi, it would be a landmark achievement if the Congress were to choose him as Chief Minister following an electoral victory.



The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

CGHS WAS ENVISIONED AS A MODEL OF DIGNIFIED HEALTHCARE FOR PUBLIC SERVANTS. TODAY, IT RISKS BECOMING A SYMBOL OF BUREAUCRATIC INDIFFERENCE. THE SUFFERING OF AIR INDIA RETIREES, EXEMPLIFIED BY CASES LIKE INDRESH HOSPITAL IN DEHRADUN, AND THE BROADER CHALLENGES WITHIN THE SCHEME DESERVE NATIONAL ATTENTION

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The Pioneer

From Frankenstein to AI: Why intelligence without understanding remains dangerous

PREM KUMAR KALRA
JYOTI KUMAR VERMA
RUPALI SATSANGI

In Frankenstein, Mary Shelley imagines a scientist who succeeds in animating lifeless matter, only to discover that creating life is not the same as creating understanding. Victor Frankenstein's creature can perceive, feel, and even reason, yet it remains tragically excluded from the moral and emotional fabric that gives meaning to intelligence. The experiment does not fail because of a lack of technical brilliance; it falters because the creator does not fully comprehend the nature of what he has brought into being. This enduring literary moment offers a powerful analogy for our present engagement with Artificial Intelligence: we have learned to build systems that can process, predict, and perform, but we are still far from creating systems that truly understand.

Since the foundational work of Alan Turing, the modelling of Data, Information, Knowledge, and Wisdom has driven the design of intelligent systems. Successive generations of AI research have introduced increasingly sophisticated tools for managing uncertainty, including certainty factors, Bayesian networks, fuzzy logic, Dempster-Shafer theory, computing with words, and belief-based reasoning.

The modelling of Data, Information, Knowledge, and Wisdom to address everyday and complex real-life challenges has evolved significantly since

Turing introduced the concept of a thinking machine. Turing theorised that to imitate an adult human mind, we must consider the first state of the mind, the education it has received, and other experiences it has undergone. His suggestion of creating a computational model of a child's mind and then "educating" it continues to echo in neural networks and hierarchical learning systems today.

Yet, limitations persist. Neural network models have advanced in architecture design, learning schemes, and evaluation metrics, but their learning mechanisms remain fundamentally mathematical optimisation processes and do not faithfully represent how the biological brain acquires and applies knowledge. The brain integrates data, prior knowledge, and accumulated wisdom simultaneously; current AI relies largely on data alone.

Equally significant is the neglect of quantum information processing. While quantum approaches have shown measurable advantages in learning efficiency and computational performance, they remain largely unexplored within mainstream AI architectures. If quantum effects indeed play a role in biological neural processing, this omission represents a major missed opportunity. Similarly, higher-order cognitive functions — consciousness, abstraction, moral reasoning, and contextual wisdom — are either absent or only superficially approximated. The result is systems that are efficient but not genuinely intelligent in the human sense.

To move forward, integrating quantum and neuromorphic computing becomes essential. The classical Church-Turing thesis, long regarded as the



oretical foundation of computation, is now increasingly questioned in light of quantum computing capabilities. Emerging evidence suggests that quantum systems may process information in ways that classical systems cannot efficiently simulate. If such processes are intrinsic to human cognition, then only quantum artificial intelligence may eventually match the brain's energy efficiency and noise tolerance.

A key opportunity lies in integrating these paradigms to develop brain-like structures capable of solving problems efficiently with minimal energy and limited data, while simultaneously providing concise explanations. Neuromorphic and brain-inspired computing emulate synaptic plasticity and energy-efficient processing observed in biological systems, while quantum computing offers exponential speed-ups in optimisation and pattern recognition. Together, they present a pathway to overcoming the limitations of current AI. Future AI systems must also be capable of explaining their reasoning. Transparency, account-

ability, and trust cannot emerge from opaque systems. This requires constructing cognitive frameworks modelled after human processes such as reasoning, memory, and decision-making. Integrating biology, psychology, and mathematics is essential for enhancing both traditional and quantum information-processing capabilities.

Incorporating models of mind, consciousness, and cognition is equally critical. Human learning integrates data, knowledge, and wisdom, whereas current AI relies primarily on data. Bridging this gap demands innovative approaches to reasoning and abstraction. It also requires a new skilling ecosystem that integrates computational thinking, biological intelligence, quantum literacy, and ethical reasoning.

Recent scholarship views AI not just as a computational tool but as a system involved in knowledge generation, making it essential to preserve human agency and critical thinking. The emerging "Einstein Test" goes beyond the Turing Test by assessing whether AI can produce genuine scientific discoveries rather than merely imitate human responses. However, despite their capabilities, current AI systems still lack true creativity, imagination, and causal reasoning. Addressing these challenges requires a structured convergence of four disciplines: biology, psychology, quantum science, mathematics, and data science. This integration is not additive but synergistic, opening possibilities such as quantum neuroinformatics, in which insights from brain science and quantum theory inform one another.

The way forward demands clear research pri-

orities: quantum-neural interfaces, cognitive architecture integration, energy-efficient learning, and ethics and value alignment. However, progress will require more than technical innovation. Educational institutions must cultivate researchers capable of working across disciplinary boundaries and questioning foundational assumptions.

The trajectory of AI development cannot rely solely on scaling existing architectures. Their dependence on massive data, their opacity, and their indifference to ethics reflect the absence of biological, cognitive, and quantum insights. The framework proposed here is not a single technology but a research philosophy — one that treats the human brain as a guide to constructing genuinely intelligent machines.

The convergence of biology, information science, quantum science, and data science offers the most promising path towards AI that is not only powerful, but also comprehensible, efficient, and aligned with human values. Realising this vision will require interdisciplinary collaboration, ethical responsibility, and a deep commitment to understanding human cognition — one of the greatest open challenges of our time.

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Order Order

HC: Can standing counsels file proceedings against State?

The Allahabad High Court has sought clarification from the Uttar Pradesh Government on whether additional Government advocates (AGAs) or standing counsel receiving retainerhip from the state can institute cases against the Government or its officers.

Justice Saurabh Lavania of the Lucknow bench of the High Court passed the order while hearing a contempt petition filed by Ashok Kumar Singh and 28 others alleging wilful disobedience of an order passed in 2025.

During the hearing, the court noted that advocate Sudhir Kumar Mishra, appearing for the petitioners, is an additional Government advocate.

The bench then sought a response from the legal remembrancer on the issue whether AGAs or standing counsel on state retainerhip are permitted to file proceedings against the state Government or its officers.

The matter has been posted for further hearing on May 18. (PTI)

**FAMILY GETS
LIFE TERM FOR
KILLING COUPLE**



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ballia

A local court here has sentenced three members of a family to life imprisonment in connection with the 2017 murder of a young couple over their relationship, police said on Wednesday.

According to the prosecution, 23-year-old Ajit Gond and 20-year-old Khushboo Rai were shot dead by the girl's family members in Jethwar village under Pakri police station limits on the night of May 29.

Ajit, a resident of Khorai Pakad village under the Fefna police station, was friends with Prince Rai, brother of Khushboo, and frequently visited his house. During this period, Ajit and Khushboo became close, which allegedly led to opposition from her family.

After the couple were killed, Ajit's mother, Shaili Devi, then filed a complaint, and police registered a case under sections of the Indian Penal Code and relevant provisions of the SC/ST Act against Prince, his mother Nirmala Rai, sister Pinki Rai, and four others — Sugriv Ram, Prakash, Umesh Kumar Gond and Umesh Sharma.

SC allows TVK MLA to participate in floor test

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday stayed the Madras High Court order which had restrained TVK MLA R Sreenivasa Sethupathi from participating in the floor test in the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly.

"This is atrocious to say the least. The High Court says the remedy is election petition but still entertains the Article 226 petition," a bench of Justices Vikram Nath, Sandeep Mehta and Vijay Bishnoi observed while hearing the plea.

Article 226 of the Constitution deals with power of High Courts to issue certain writs.

The Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) Government in Tamil Nadu crossed a major hurdle on Wednesday, winning a confidence-boost-



ing trust vote by a 144:22 margin amid a walkout by the principal opposition party DMK and a divided AIADMK whose one faction supported the C Joseph Vijay-led Government.

While issuing notice on Sethupathi's plea challenging the High Court's May 12 interim order, the apex court also stayed the proceedings pending before the High Court in the matter.

"In the meantime, the



Not mandatory to go to temple to prove belief: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Observing that Hinduism is a way of life, the Supreme Court on Wednesday said it is not necessary for a Hindu to mandatorily go to a temple or perform a ritual in order to remain a Hindu and even lighting a lamp inside house is enough to prove one's belief.

The observation of a nine-judge constitution bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant came while hearing petitions related to discrimination against women at religious places, including the Sabarimala temple in Kerala, and on the ambit of religious

freedom practised by multiple faiths, including Dawoodi Bohras.

Justices BV Nagarathna, MM Sundresh, Ahsanuddin Amanullah, Aravind Kumar, Augustine George Masih, Prasanna B Varale, R Mahadevan and Joyimalya Bagchi are also part of the nine-judge bench.

As the hearing commenced on 15th day of hearing, advocate Dr G Mohan Gopal, appearing for one of the intervenors submitted that there has been demand for social justice emerging from within religious communities.

"Hinduism was defined as a religious category. Thereafter, in 1966, it was



held that a Hindu is one who accepts the Vedas as the highest authority in all matters religion and philoso-

phy. They never asked me. None of us ever said that. "Now, I have the highest respect for the Vedas and

great admiration for it. But is it a fact that every person today classified as Hindu accepts the Vedas as the highest authority in all spiritual and philosophical matters?" he asked.

Responding to his submission, Justice Nagarathna said, "That is why Hinduism is called as a way of life. It is not necessary for a Hindu to mandatorily go to a temple or perform a ritual in order to remain a Hindu."

She said one need not be ritualistic and nobody can come in the way for people having their faith.

CJI also remarked, "Even if an individual lights a lamp inside his hut is enough to

prove his religion." The hearing is underway.

The top court had earlier observed that if individuals start questioning every religious practice or matters of religion before a constitutional court, then there will be hundreds of petitions and every religion will "break" due to this.

A five-judge Constitution bench had lifted a ban that prevented women between the ages of 10 and 50 from entering the Sabarimala Ayyappa temple in a 4:1 majority verdict in September 2018, ruling that the centuries-old Hindu religious practice was illegal and unconstitutional.

Medical association moves SC over NEET-UG paper leak

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A medical association has moved the Supreme Court alleging "systemic failure" in the conduct of the NEET-UG 2026 exam for admissions in undergraduate medical courses and seeking reforms in the test system following the cancellation of the exam over irregularities.

The NEET (UG) 2026 exam held on May 3 by the National Testing Agency (NTA) was cancelled on May 12 amid allegations of paper leak which is now being probed by the CBI.

The Federation of All India Medical Association (FAIMA), through lawyer Tanvi Dubey,



has moved the top court seeking a complete overhaul of the national testing framework, including the replacement of the NTA with a more robust and autonomous body.

The plea also referred to

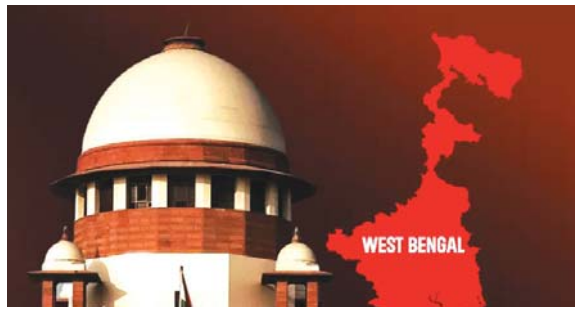
replace the NTA with a "technologically advanced and autonomous body" to restore the integrity of medical entrance exams.

FAIMA also asked the court to constitute a high-powered monitoring committee, chaired by a retired Supreme Court judge and including cybersecurity and forensic experts, to oversee the re-conduct of the 2026 exam.

The cancellation of the exam has left over 22 lakh medical aspirants and their families anxious about the next steps, including the fresh examination date, admit cards, examination centres and the counselling timeline.

news reports that "guess papers" circulating on encrypted platforms like WhatsApp and Telegram matched more than 100 questions from the actual exam paper. It urged the government to direct the Government to

**SC to hear in July
plea on killing of BJP
workers in Bengal**



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday said it would hear in July a plea concerning the alleged killing of three BJP workers in West Bengal after the 2018 local bodies elections in the state.

"What remains in this matter now?" a bench of Justices Vikram Nath, Sandeep Mehta and Vijay Bishnoi asked senior advocate Gaurav Bhatia, who had filed the plea in 2018 and was also appearing for the brother of one of the deceased. Bhatia referred to the change in circumstances in the state. "Substantial change or sea change," the bench observed.

Suvendu Adhikari on May 9 took oath as West Bengal's first BJP chief minister.

The BJP secured 207 seats in the 294-member assembly, ending the TMC's 15-year rule in West Bengal in

the recently concluded assembly elections.

During the hearing, Bhatia urged the bench to post the plea for hearing in July to enable him to seek further instructions. "You should take a proactive step in ensuring that things move in the right direction," the bench observed and posted the plea for hearing in July.

While hearing the matter on February 17, the top court asked the petitioner why he had not approached the Calcutta High Court with his grievance. Bhatia had said three ghastly murders that took place in West Bengal were brought to the notice of the apex court.

He had argued that 19 murders, which were political in nature, took place in the state at that time and the brother and family members of one of the deceased were receiving death threats from some influential persons.

SC agrees to hear plea on minimum attendance in law colleges

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday agreed to hear a plea challenging the Delhi High Court verdict which had said that no law college or university can bar students from appearing in examinations due to a lack of minimum attendance.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath, Sandeep Mehta and Vijay Bishnoi observed that if such a position were to be accepted, the hostels of the National Law University and law colleges could become "just boarding and lodging facilities".

The top court, however, refused to stay the High



Court's November 3 verdict and said it would hear the matter and decide it.

The bench sought responses from the Bar Council of India (BCI) and others on the plea challenging the High Court's verdict, which had also asked the BCI to re-

evaluate the mandatory attendance norms.

The High Court had said it was of the strong view that attendance norms for education in general and legal education in particular cannot be made so stringent that they lead to mental

trauma, let alone the death of a student.

It had delivered the judgment while disposing of a suo motu petition, initiated by the Supreme Court and transferred to the High Court, in relation to the death of law student Sushant Rohilla by suicide in 2016 after allegedly being barred from sitting for the semester exams due to lack of requisite attendance.

Rohilla, a third-year law student, had hanged himself at his home here on August 10, 2016, after his college allegedly barred him from sitting for the semester exams due to lack of requisite attendance. He left behind a note, saying he

was a failure and did not wish to live. The High Court had directed that it would be mandatory for all educational institutions and universities to constitute grievance redressal committees (GRCs) in terms of the University Grants Commission Regulations, 2023.

Observing that GRCs were for safeguarding the interests of students, including their mental health, it had directed the UGC to initiate consultations and consider amending the UGC regulations.

"The BCI shall undertake a re-evaluation of the mandatory attendance norms for the three-year and five-year LLB courses in India..." it had said.

**Can't let entire generation be ruined by
obscene content on mobiles: Delhi HC**

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday asked Google and Apple to strictly act against the dissemination of obscene pornographic content through mobile applications hosted on their online platforms, remarking that it cannot permit an entire generation to be "ruined".

A bench of Chief Justice D K Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia said in the present legal framework, the social media intermediaries have to play the "most vital role" and they should act against the dissemina-



tion of pornographic content not only upon receiving a complaint but even at the time of uploading by exercising due diligence.

It also asked the Centre's Indian Computer Emergency Response Team to check

the dissemination of such content. The court was hearing a PIL by Rubika Thapa against the hosting of mobile applications offering vulgar and pornographic content on platforms run by Google and Apple.

Rani Kapur moves SC to restrain Priya Kapur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court has agreed to hear on May 14 an application filed by late industrialist Sunjay Kapur's mother Rani Kapur seeking a direction to restrain his wife Priya Kapur and others from interfering with the functioning of the 'RK Family Trust' during the pendency of mediation proceedings.

The apex court had on May 7 appointed former Chief Justice of India DY Chandrachud to act as a mediator in the dispute between the 80-year-old Rani Kapur and Priya Kapur over the family trust.

The matter was mentioned on Tuesday before a bench of Justices JB Pardiwala and Ujjal Bhuyan.

"Looks like we have entered into an arena where Mahabharata will look very small," the bench had orally observed while listing the application for hearing on May 14.



In her fresh application, Rani Kapur has alleged that Priya Kapur and others were attempting to assume control over some companies and assets linked to the disputed family estate.

The application also raised an apprehension that attempts may be made to alienate or transfer the assets during the pendency of mediation proceedings.

Rani Kapur has sought a direction to

restrain Priya Kapur and others from interfering with the functioning of the trust and some companies linked to the family estate during the pendency of mediation proceedings.

On May 7, the top court said the parties should participate in the mediation proceedings with an open mind.

"We make one request to all the parties before us that they may not make any statements in public and may not go on social media. This being a family matter, the endeavour on their part should be to get the disputes resolved at the earliest and put an end to the entire matter," the bench had said.

It had said it would be in the interest of one and all if they were able to resolve the entire matter before the mediator otherwise this was going to be a long drawn litigation.

The bench had made clear that this mediation was confined to the present matter.

SC quashes case against Kolkata hospital

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court has quashed a criminal complaint against a Kolkata-based hospital and its chairman, saying that billing discrepancies and service-related grievances are primarily civil in nature and do not constitute criminal offences.

A bench comprising Justice Pamidighantam Sri Narasimha and Justice Alok Aradhe, in a judgement delivered on Tuesday, set aside a 2023 order of the Calcutta High Court, which had suggested that a prima facie criminal case was made out against the Narayana Multispecialty Hospital at Barasat in West Bengal.

The case stemmed from a complaint filed by a man whose mother was treated for a fractured femur at the hospital in 2021. The com-



plainant alleged that the hospital intentionally charged ₹2,500 for an HRCT test that was never performed and failed to provide medical records promptly.

An HRCT (high-resolution computed tomography) scan is a specialised imaging test that provides highly detailed, cross-sectional, 3D images of lungs and chest tissue.

He further alleged that hospital staff behaved improperly and issued threats when questioned.

On the basis of these allegations, a magisterial court had issued notices against

the hospital, its chairman, and staff under Sections 406 (criminal breach of trust), 420 (cheating), and 120B (criminal conspiracy) of the IPC, along with provisions of the West Bengal Clinical Establishments Act, 2017.

The hospital maintained that the HRCT test was initially proposed but later deemed unnecessary by doctors and said once the error was identified, a revised bill was issued. The top court held that the essential "foundational ingredients" of criminal offences alleged against the hospital were missing.

It said for the commission of offence of cheating, there must be a "dishonest intention" from the very beginning.

In this case, the billing discrepancy appeared to be an "inadvertence" rather than a fraudulent plot, especially since the hospital proactively offered a refund.

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Withdrawal of funds to be automated: EPFO

Retirement fund body EPFO will soon automate the process for settling final provident fund withdrawal claims, fast-tracking the money transfer to the applicant's bank accounts, a top official said on Wednesday. The Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) has more than seven crore members.

At present, partial or advance withdrawal claims of up to ₹5 lakh are settled through auto mode, and the deadline for the auto-settlement mode is three days from filing the claim.

Speaking at the ASSOCHAM's National Seminar on New Labour Codes, Central Provident Fund Commissioner, EPFO, Ramesh Krishnamurthi, said, "We are also going to initiate, as far as feasible, auto-settlement for now... which was (available) only for advances. Now we are going in for auto-settlement of final withdrawals." He further added that the EPFO is going in for auto-settlement and auto-transfer of provident fund accounts in case a member shifts employers.

India, Chile review progress of trade pact talks

India and Chile, a South American nation, on Wednesday reviewed the progress of negotiations for the proposed free trade agreement and discussed modalities for its early conclusion, an official statement said.

Chilean Foreign Affairs Minister Francisco Perez Mackenna held meetings with Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal and Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal here. The Chilean minister is leading a delegation here. "Apart from discussing the modalities for early conclusion of Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA), the interactions also covered a broad range of issues relating to trade facilitation, market access, investment promotion and strengthening institutional economic engagement between the two countries," the commerce ministry said. Both sides also deliberated upon ways to enhance collaboration in sectors such as critical minerals, renewable energy, agri-business, infrastructure, pharmaceuticals, digital services, logistics and advanced manufacturing.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | THURSDAY | MAY 14, 2026

BUSINESS11

AI could add \$500b to India's economy by 2030: Study

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Artificial Intelligence (AI) has the potential to contribute over \$500 billion (about ₹47.81 lakh crore) to India's economy by 2030, according to a new joint study by IBM and IndiaAI, a MeitY initiative. The report, titled "From Promise to Power: How AI Is Redefining India's Economic Future", surveyed 1,500 Indian executives from a range of industries and organisations, covering various leadership levels, including CXOs. The study was supplemented by a pulse survey of 405 Indian executives.

The report revealed that 80

per cent of Indian business leaders surveyed believe AI investments will directly influence the nation's GDP growth.

"AI could contribute more than \$500 billion to India's economy by 2030, positioning the country among the world's most dynamic AI-driven economies. Few countries are stepping into the AI era with India's mix of scale, digital muscle, and ambition," the report said.

Around 73 per cent of Indian executives believe the country will be a leading AI nation by 2030—a bet built on a vast market, a pioneering digital public infrastructure, and the world's largest IT services workforce, according

to the report. However, the research also highlighted a critical "inflection gap", with 72 per cent of surveyed organisations acknowledging they currently lag behind their global peers in AI adop-

tion. Currently, only 15 per cent of organisations are scaling AI through cross-functional investments, while the remaining 85 per cent are stuck in the pilot stage.

Ministry of Electronics &

Information Technology (MeitY) Secretary S Krishnan said India is no longer just participating in the global AI conversation but helping shape it.

"Our vision is clear. AI must evolve as an extension of our people's aspirations, driving inclusive growth and national progress. Guided by our vision of Viksit Bharat, we are advancing a human-centric approach to AI rooted in trust, ethics, and national sovereignty," he said.

The study identified significant barriers to AI readiness. About 77 per cent of respondents cited a lack of accessible, affordable and secure cloud infrastructure as a major hurdle, while 57

per cent outlined uneven data quality.

Furthermore, a growing skills gap also poses challenges.

Currently, only about 30 per cent of employees possess the level of AI literacy that businesses require.

To meet future demands, respondents indicate this figure must rise to nearly 57 per cent by 2030, translating to a need for a talent pool of over 350 million AI-literate professionals in the country, as per the report.

Sandip Patel, Managing Director of IBM India & South Asia, noted that AI could become one of the most powerful growth engines for the Indian economy.

Govt hikes paddy MSP by ₹72 to ₹2,441/qtl; sunflower seed sees steepest rise at ₹622

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Government on Wednesday announced a hike in the Minimum Support Price (MSP) for paddy by ₹72 to ₹2,441 per quintal for the 2026-27 kharif marketing season, while steeper increases for pulses, oilseeds and cotton aimed at reducing import dependency and encouraging crop diversification.

The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA), chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, approved MSPs for 14 kharif crops ahead of sowing, which typically begins in June with the onset of the southwest monsoon.

For paddy, the MSP for common and A-grade varieties stands at ₹2,441 and ₹2,461 per quintal, respectively for 2026-27 kharif marketing season (September-October). The MSP for cotton (medium staple) has been raised by ₹57 to ₹8,267 per quintal, while the long staple variety will fetch ₹8,667 per quintal—the second-highest absolute increase among all crops.

The highest absolute increase, however, has been recommended for sunflower seed at ₹622 per quintal, taking its MSP to ₹8,343 per quintal. Nigerseed (up ₹515 to ₹10,052/qtl) and sesamum (up ₹500 to ₹10,346/qtl) also received significant increases. Among other oilseeds, soyabean (yellow) was raised by

₹380 to ₹5,708 per quintal and groundnut by ₹254 to ₹7,517 per quintal.

In pulses, tur (arhar) MSP was raised by ₹450 to ₹8,450 per quintal, urad by ₹400 to ₹8,200 per quintal, while moong saw a marginal increase of ₹12 to ₹8,780 per quintal.

For other cereals, jowar (hybrid) MSP has been fixed at ₹4,023 per quintal (up ₹324), with the Maldandi variety at ₹4,073 per quintal.

Bajra has been raised by ₹125 to ₹2,900 per quintal, ragi by ₹319 to ₹5,205 per quintal, and maize by ₹10 to ₹2,410 per quintal.

Briefing reporters, Information and Broadcasting Minister Ashwini Vaishnav said the MSPs have been fixed to ensure remunerative prices for farmers and are at least 50 per cent above the cost of production across all 14 crops.

The margins are estimated to be highest for moong (61 per cent), followed by bajra and maize (56 per cent each) and tur/arhar (54 per cent).

Govt approves incentive for coal gasification projects with outlay of ₹37,500 crore

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Union Cabinet on Wednesday approved a ₹37,500-crore incentive scheme to promote coal gasification projects, aimed at boosting clean energy production and reducing dependence on forex-guzzling imports of LNG, urea, and methanol, while insulating the country from global price volatility and supply chain disruptions.

The Union Cabinet under the chairmanship of Prime Minister Narendra Modi approved the scheme for

promotion of surface coal/lignite gasification projects with a financial outlay of ₹37,500 crore, an official

statement said. "An outlay of ₹37,500 crore has been kept for this scheme, and there will be an investment of

Stock markets snap four days of losses; end marginally higher

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

Benchmark equity indices Sensex and Nifty ended marginally higher on Wednesday, snapping their four-day losing streak, as elevated crude oil prices and persistent geopolitical uncertainties restricted the upside.

The 30-share BSE Sensex rose 49.74 points, or 0.07 per cent, to settle at 74,608.98. During the day, the index touched a high of 75,191.57 and a low of 74,134.48, gyrating 1,057.09 points.

The 50-share NSE edged higher by 33.05 points or 0.14 per cent to end at 23,412.60. From the Sensex constituents, Asian Paints, Tata Steel, Adani Ports, Bharat Electronics, Bharti Airtel and Larsen & Toubro were among the winners. Mahindra & Mahindra, Infosys, Tata Consultancy Services, Sun Pharma and Tech Mahindra were among the biggest laggards.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark,

Change	Top Gainers	Top Losers
49.74 (0.07%)	Asian Paints 4.48	M&M -2.07
	Tata Steel 3.63	Power Grid -1.52
	Bharat Electronics 2.93	Infosys -1.51
	Adani Ports 2.79	TCS -1.21
	Bharti Airtel 1.78	Sun Pharma -1.16

fell 0.5 per cent to \$107.27 per barrel. Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth ₹1,959.39 crore on Tuesday, according to exchange

Gold soars by ₹8,550, silver by ₹20,500 after import duty hike

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Gold prices soared by ₹8,550 to a little over ₹1.65 lakh per 10 grams in the local market here on Wednesday after the Government increased the import duty on precious metals to 15 per cent.

Silver prices jumped by ₹20,500 to ₹2,97,500 per kg in Delhi markets from ₹2,77,000 per kg (inclusive of all taxes) on the previous day, according to the All India Sarafa Association.

Gold of 99.9 per cent purity increased by ₹8,550, or over 5 per cent, to ₹1,65,350 per 10 grams (inclusive of all taxes) from the previous close of ₹1,56,800 per 10 grams.

The Government on Wednesday sharply hiked import duty on gold and silver to 15 per cent from 6 per cent earlier to discourage purchase and trim non-essential imports in the backdrop of a

ballooning import bill amid the West Asia crisis.

Also, import duty on platinum has been raised to 15.4 per cent from 6.4 per cent. Consequential changes have also been made to other

items such as gold/silver dore, coins, findings, etc. The new duties are effective from Wednesday.

The duty hike follows Prime Minister Narendra Modi's clarification call for curbs on gold purchases, along with other austerity measures, to reduce avoidable foreign-exchange expenditure.

Local traders said the actual impact of the higher levy would play out over the coming days once the increased duty begins reflecting in purchase bills.

"The recent hike in India's gold import duty is likely to raise local prices and temporarily dampen physical demand. However, investors should not view this as a

reason to panic. Gold continues to hold its appeal as a safe-haven asset, particularly in times of global uncertainty and domestic currency pressures," Hareesh V, Head of Commodity Research, Geojit Investments Ltd, said.

A weak rupee also inflated the prices of precious metals, analysts said. The rupee dropped to a low of 95.80 against the US dollar amid concerns over forex outflows and high crude oil prices.

India is the world's second-largest consumer of precious metals, and prices have rallied in recent months amid an unabated rise in demand, including for investment purposes. Gold is

India's second-largest commodity import after crude oil, and rising purchases have added to foreign-exchange outflows, pressuring the rupee to record lows.

The Gem & Jewellery Export Promotion Council cautioned that raising gold import duty does not curb imports but inflates prices.

Jewellery retailers stated that imposing quantitative restrictions on gold and silver imports, rather than raising import duties, would be a more effective way to curb the country's current account deficit.

Brent crude traded above the \$107 per barrel level in global markets on Wednesday.

DRI, Customs officers to intensify vigil on gold smuggling post import duty hike

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The revenue intelligence and customs officers are likely to intensify surveillance and step up vigil on international borders to check possible gold smuggling after the sharp hike in customs duty on the yellow metal to 15 per cent on Wednesday, officials said.

The tax officers will step up monitoring of land and coastal infiltration routes, domestic handlers acting as distribution nodes, organised carrier networks, and foreign national-based syndicates to deter syndicates from exploiting the gold market.

"The idea is to disrupt the supply chain and intercept

gold smuggling syndicate and cross border cartels. Intelligence driven surveillance and enforcement will be key in tackling the challenge of gold smuggling," an official told PTI.

Effective May 13, import duty on gold and silver has been increased from 6 per cent to 15 per cent and that on platinum has been raised from 6.4 per cent to 15.4 per cent. Consequential changes have also been made to

other items such as gold/silver dore, coins, findings, etc. Although import duty does not have a direct co-relation with smuggling, it is perceived that higher duties lead to spurt in grey market activity.

Gold's cultural, economic and social significance, along with high liquidity and value, has fuelled smuggling over the years.

Global uncertainties, geopolitical tensions and high inflation amplifies international gold demand, thereby increasing smuggling.

Smuggling of the precious metal is mostly concentrated in the states of Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, Gujarat and West Bengal, officials said.

Gold, silver imports from Dubai may rise after duty hike: GTRI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

The significant increase in the import duty on gold and silver from 6 per cent to 15 per cent may lead to an increase in imports from Dubai through the free trade agreement route, think tank GTRI said on Wednesday.

It said that the duty hike also sharply changes the economics of precious metal imports routed through the United Arab Emirates under the India-UAE Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA).

India had allowed imports of gold from Dubai at tariffs one percentage point below the normal Most-Favoured-Nation (MFN) rate through a Tariff Rate Quota (TRQ) system.

The quota began at 120 tonnes annually in 2022 and is set to rise to 200 tonnes by 2027, nearly one-fourth of India's yearly gold imports.

"With the new MFN tariff structure taking effective duties to 15 per cent, gold imported under the UAE quota would enter at 14 per cent. The widening tariff gap could encourage greater routing of global bullion through

Dubai, even though the UAE is not a miner of gold or silver," the Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI) said. Under the CEPA, India had also agreed to gradually reduce import duties on silver from 10 per cent to zero over a ten-year period beginning in May 2022.

The concessional tariff on silver imports from the UAE currently stands at 7 per cent.

"With India now raising the general tariff to 15 per cent, the duty gap has widened to 8 per cent, creating a major arbitrage opportunity for imports routed through Dubai. That margin is scheduled to widen further each year until CEPA tariffs fall to zero by 2031," GTRI Founder Ajay Srivastava said.

Rupee crashes to record 95.80 against USD

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The rupee on Wednesday slipped to an all-time low of 95.80 against the US dollar, and settled at 95.67 near its record closing low level, as the cumulative strain of elevated crude prices and West Asia geopolitical concerns offset hopes of lower demand for the US dollar due to import curbs.

Forex traders said possible RBI intervention and duty-led compression of gold imports helped moderate further weakness for the USD/INR pair, but the rupee was pressured by the trajectory of crude and the West Asia situation.

The rupee has become the worst-performing currency in Asia for the year, registering a loss of over 6 per cent so far this year, as elevated crude oil prices, a strong dollar and concerns regarding the West Asia crisis weighed on investor sentiments, traders said.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.52, registering a gain of 16 paise from its previous all-time closing low. In a highly volatile trade, the USD/INR pair witnessed an intra-day high of 95.51 and a low of 95.80 against the greenback before settling at 95.67 (provisional), up 1 paise from its previous close.

The rupee depreciated 40 paise to close at a fresh all-time low of 95.68 against the US dollar on Tuesday.

"On the rupee, USD/INR around 95.60 reflects the cumulative strain of elevated

Date	Rate (₹ per US \$)	Change
May 6	94.22	+27p
May 7	94.49	+69p
May 8	94.49	-27p
May 11	95.28	-79p
May 12	95.68	-40p
May 13	95.67	+01p

crude prices and the West Asia geopolitical premium. Active RBI intervention and the duty-led compression of gold imports should help moderate further weakness. The path of the rupee from here will be shaped less by gold and more by the trajectory of crude and the West Asia situation," Anindya Banerjee, Head of Commodity and Currency Research, Kotak Securities, said.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 98.51, up 0.22 per cent.

"We expect the rupee to trade with a negative bias amid rising crude oil prices, concerns over inflation and geopolitical tensions between the US and Iran. However, any intervention by the RBI may support the rupee at lower levels. USD/INR spot price is expected to trade in a range of 95.45 to 96.15," Anuj Choudhary, Research analyst at Mirae Asset ShareKhan, said.



Should he choose to stand again, all the signs suggest he will be re-elected. A distant dream for European leaders. His success can be attributed to the richest and poorest States in India. India lacks the highly educated workforce that China has. There is still too much bureaucracy, and India

Growth is uneven, and there is a wide gap between the richest and poorest States in India. India lacks the highly educated workforce that China has. There is still too much bureaucracy, and India

But at current growth rates, India's economy will quadruple by 2050. India will then be the world's second-largest economy, rivalling the US. I have travelled to almost every State in India and see signs of development everywhere – new, modern airports; better roads leading to the most remote corners of

He asks no one to make sacrifices for the environment. The message is that India can lift 1.5 billion people out of poverty through green growth. There is no longer a

China anchors its modernity in its own roots – in Confucianism, Taoism and Buddhism. The BJP is currently the world's largest political party, with over 100 million members. The party has dedicated activists in every single constituency across northern and central India. The party has achieved something truly unique and unprecedented in India: the BJP enjoys the same level of support amongst high-caste, low-caste and untouchable communities. It has the support of both India's bil-

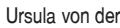
Many of the BJP's proposals are common sense – such as the idea that there should not be a separate marriage law under which Muslim men can divorce more easily than other men. But in the emergence of a new, strong India rooted in Hindu dharma, the

The author is a Norwegian diplomat and has also served in the Norwegian Government as Minister of International Development and Minister of the Environment, and as Under-Secretary-General of the United Nations. He was also Executive Director of the UN Environment Programme from 2016 to 2018.

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ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Brussels

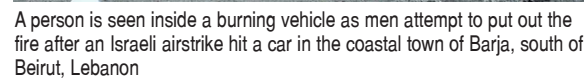
The EU's Agency for Fundamental Rights said in 2024 that one in four LGBTQ+ citizens polled had been sub-



jected to the scientifically discredited practice to attempt to change their sexual orientation or gender identity. Reports of the practice were highest in Greece, Cyprus, the Czech Republic, Estonia, and Slovakia.

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ BEIRUT

Lebanon and Israel are scheduled to hold another round of direct talks in Washington on Thursday as the Trump administration pushes for a breakthrough between the two neighbours that have been at a state of war since Israel was created in 1948.



detail the number of people in each vehicle. Two of Wednesday's drone attacks hit a highway linking Beirut with the southern port city of Sidon, while a third, reported the state-run National news agency, struck the town of Saadiyat,

A fourth strike on Sidon's northern entrance happened in the early afternoon, hitting a car, according to state media. An Associated Press photographer saw the bodies of three people killed in two of

Lebanese Health Minister Youssef Makan Nasserredine told reporters Tuesday that since the ceasefire went into effect, 380 people have been killed and 1,122 have been wounded. That brings the toll since the war began to 2,882 killed and 8,786 wounded.

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Ankara

Turkiye has carried out such raids in the past. IS has carried out deadly attacks in Türkiye over the years, including a shooting at an Istanbul nightclub during New Year celebrations in 2017.



 **Retail Asset Centre:** Axis House, Jaypee Green Wirth Town, Tower-2, 4th Floor, Sec-128, Noida Expressway, Noida-201301 **Corporate Office:** 'Axis House', Block-B, Bombay Deyling Mills Compound, Pandarav Budhkar Marg, Worli, Mumbai-400025 **Registered Office:** 'Trishul', 3rd floor, opposite Samarthwasa Temple, Law Garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-380006 Also at: Axis Bank Ltd. Hiraldwala House, Upper Ground Floor & First Floor, K.G. Marg, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001

APPENDIX IV (Refer Rule – 8(i)) POSSESSION NOTICE (For Immovable Property)

Whereas The undersigned being the Authorized Officer of Axis Bank Ltd. under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest, Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred on him under sub-section (1) of section 11 of the said Act read with sub-section (1) of section 2002 issued demand notice dated 12th July 2023 calling M/S Balaji Impex, Mr. Rakesh Kumar & Mr. Anil Kumar (Borrower/ Co Borrower/ Mortgagee/Guarantor) to repay the amount mentioned in the notice beisingar from the various documents executed byyou, we hereby call upon you to make payment of Eight Hundred and Twenty Four Lacs, 1,71,88,824/- (Rupees One Crore Seventy One Lakhs Eighty Eight Thousand Eight Hundred and Twenty Four Lacs) only as on 31st May 2023 together with cost of interest with in sixty days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/Mortgagee(s)/Guarantor(s) above said having failed to repay the amount, the notice is hereby given to the Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/Mortgagee(s)/ Guarantor(s) and the Public in General that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of power conferred on him under sub-section (1) of section 11 of the said Act read with sub-section (1) of section 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred on him under sub-section (1) of section 11 of the said Act. The Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Mortgagee(s)/Guarantor(s) above said in particular and the Public in General is hereby cautioned not to deal with the properties and any dealings with the properties will be subject to the charge of the Axis Bank Ltd. for an amount of Rs. 1,71,88,824/- (Rupees One Crore Seventy One Lakhs Eighty Eight Thousand Eight Hundred Twenty Four only) due as on 31st May 2023 together with further interest thereon at the contractual rate of interest payable on the said property. The Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Mortgagee(s)/Guarantor(s)'s attention is directed to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

Description of Immovable Property

All That Part And Partial Plot No. 55, Land Admeasuring 200 Sq. Mtr. Pkt-16, Sector 20 Rohini Residential Scheme New Delhi-110065, Together With The Right To Use Common Areas Of Building The Part To Note That This Certificate Of Possession Is Issued In Respect Of Facilities Amenities In And About The Property And To Operate Thereon To Co Connected To The Flat/unit/office Premises, Both Present And Future And Easement/entire And Together With All Fixtures And Fittings, Both Present And Future Bounded As Underin The Name Of Mr. Rakesh Kumar, Nair – As Per Deed, West – As Per Deed, South – As Per Deed, East– As Per Deed

Notwithstanding to the Possession in Sub Section 13 of Section 13 of The Above said Act, You Shall Not Transfer By Way Of Sale, Lease Or Otherwise Any Of The Assets Stated Under Security Referred To in This Notice Without Priorwritten Consent Of Our Bank.

Dated: 14.05.2026, Place: Delhi **Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.**

2. L&L Exports Private Limited,
Represented by its Director No - 302, 3rd
Floor, Express Tower, C/2, Nanivabagah,
Azadpur, North Delhi-110 033.

... Defendants

It is hereby informed that our client,
Timescans Logistics (India) Limited, has
instituted a Commercial Suit for recovery of
money against Red Hawk Freight Solutions
LLP and L&L Exports Private Limited.

In this regard, the Hon'ble court has directed
us to issue a paper publication to the 1st
Defendant (Red Hawk Freight Solutions LLP).

Accordingly, we hereby inform that the above
case is posted for hearing on 09.06.2026
before The Hon'ble Principle Commercial
Court Egmore for the appearance of the 1st
Defendant (Red Hawk Freight Solutions LLP).

Failing which the matter will be decided on
merits.

T.V.Suresh Kumar
ADVOCATE
TSK Legal

Temple Tower, H-5 ,7TH floor, #672, Anna
Salai, Nandanam, Chennai-600035

Now, the above noted flat is being transferred in favour of Mrs. Anshu Bala Mehta D/o Late Ved Prakash R/o B-3, Sector-61, Noida, (U.P.) on the basis of registered Power of Attorney dated 19/03/1997 having document number 1344. Any person having any objection towards the above transfer must appear before the group housing department of Noida Authority within 30 days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which such claim shall be deemed to have been waived and no objection shall be entertained thereafter.

Anshu Bala Mehta
Applicant

PUBLIC NOTICE

Mr. Anriti Rishi has approached ICICI Bank Ltd., Ghaziabad, U.P (Bank) to avail a loan for purchase of Property No. 86, (355.5 sq. yds.), Block-B, Ramprastha, Sector-12, Ghaziabad, U.P from Mrs. Surinder Aggarwal, Mr. Neeraj Aggarwal, Mr. Tarun Aggarwal & Ms. Chhavi Aggarwal, who have represented that they are the absolute owners of the said property, having inherited from late Mr. Ravinder Kumar Aggarwal (being his Class-I legal heirs) who owned the same by virtue of a Sale Deed dated 10.07.2000 (Doc. No. 8404). anybody, person, body corporate has any right, lien or claim whatsoever on the said property, then he/she/it may contact the undersigned with documentary proof of claim within 15 days of publication of this notice, otherwise it shall be deemed that either there are no claims or the same have been waived off. No claim or objection shall be entertained thereafter and Bank shall proceed to advance the loan on mortgaging of the said property.

Amit Kumar, Advocac
Narang & Associates

D-28, Jangpura Extension, New Delhi-110017

Details of the bid may be seen shortly at e-procurement portal website i.e. www.assamtenders.gov.in and also in the office of the undersigned during office hours from **11:00 AM to 5:00 PM**. Amendment/Addendum to the SBD, if any, and further notifications shall appear in this website and also at the office of the undersigned during office hours. The contractor/bidder must be registered with the Electronic Tendering System (ETS) of PWD, Assam website www.assamtenders.gov.in. Schemes are being approved by the competent authority. In the event of non-sanction of the Schemes, the bids may be cancelled and no claim what so ever on this account shall be entertained from the bidders.

Sl. No.	Name of work	Approx. Value of work (in Rs)	Bid Security	Bid Processing Fee	Completion period
1.	Proposed Judicial Qtr. Grade II (G+2) for SDJM Court Complex, Titabar, Jorhat	4,44,88,798.00	2% for General category or 1% for Reserved category on value of work	8,900.00	15(Fifteen) Months)

Note:

- (i) Value of work may vary according to the detailed NIT.
- (ii) All terms and conditions will be as per the Bidding Documents.
- (iii) The Press Notice will be a part of the Bidding Documents.

DIPR/C/PIO/42/14-May-26

**Chief Engineer, PWD (Building)
Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-03.**

Russian ship sinks near Spain, nuke spill feared

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Madrid

A Russian ship that sank in the Mediterranean after its engine room exploded may have been carrying pieces for nuclear reactors used in submarines, a Spanish Government document shows.

The Ursa Major sank on December 23, 2024 between Spain and Algeria while allegedly on a journey from St Petersburg to Russia's eastern Vladivostok.

Two crew members were lost while 14 other people were saved by Spanish rescue craft. It has emerged that the Ursa Major's Russian captain told Spanish port authorities following his



rescue that the vessel was carrying parts for nuclear reactors suitable for use in submarines. In a written response to opposition law-

makers, the Spanish Government wrote that the ship's captain "confessed" that the ship was carrying "components for two nuclear reactors similar to those used in submarines." The response was included in a document registered by the Spanish parliament on February 23 and reported by CNN on Tuesday. The document has since been seen by *The Associated Press*.

At the time of the sinking, the Russian state-owned ship owner, Oboronlogistika, said that the Ursa Major was sabotaged. It said three powerful explosions damaged the boat just above the water line in what the company described as a "terrorist attack." Oboronlogistika was established under Russia's defence ministry and placed under US and European Union sanctions for its ties to Russia's military.

Pak receives \$1.3 bn loan from IMF: Central bank



SAJJAD HUSSAIN
■ Islamabad

Pakistan has received \$1.3 billion from the International Monetary Fund under two separate ongoing financing arrangements, the central bank said on Wednesday.

Funding was secured on Tuesday through separate International Monetary Fund (IMF) programmes, split between the Extended Fund Facility (EFF) and the Resilience and Sustainability Facility (RSF), aiming to stabilise Pakistan's external payments and help it fight climate-related hazards.

According to the State Bank of Pakistan (SBP), the IMF had approved the disbursement of USD 1.1bn under the EFF and around \$220 million under the RSF. This is the part of the fund agreed in September 2024 to provide \$7 billion over a period of 37 months under EFF, while it decided to provide \$1.4 billion under RSF.

"The IMF Executive Board completed the third review under the EFF in its meeting held on May 8 and approved the disbursement of Special Drawing Rights (SDR) 760 million for Pakistan," the State Bank of Pakistan (SBP) said in a post on X. "Furthermore, the IMF Executive Board has also approved the disbursement of the second tranche of SDR 154 million under the Resilience and Sustainability Facility (RSF)," it said. "Accordingly, SBP has received SDR 914 million (equivalent to about \$1.3 billion) under the EFF and RSF on May 12 from the IMF," it said. The bank noted the amount will update the country's foreign exchange reserves for the week ending May 15. Last week, the executive board of the IMF agreed to provide Pakistan with about USD 1 billion under the EFF and about \$210 million under the RSF. (PTI)

10,000 foreign students, including Indians, probed for OPT fraud

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

The US Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) said it has identified 10,000 foreign students, including several from India, who claim to be working for highly suspect employers by misusing the Optional Practical Training (OPT) component of their visas.

OPT allows foreign nationals who enter the United States on a student visa to work in the US for 12, or in some cases 24, months. It also allows students to transition to an H-



1B visa sponsored by employers.

Addressing a press conference on Tuesday, acting Director of ICE Todd Lyons said the OPT component of the student visa programme has "become a

magnet for fraud" and has been the subject of many investigations by the Department of Homeland Security.

"We've encountered cases involving espionage, biological threats, intellectual property theft, visa and employment fraud, and even scams targeting elderly Americans, all perpetrated by individuals abusing their status as students," Lyons said.

"Our nation will not tolerate security threats originating from the foreign student programme," Lyons said. (PTI)

Charles to present UK Govt agenda as Starmer faces pressure

DANICA KIRKA/PAN PYLAS
■ London

King Charles III on Wednesday will deliver the British Government's legislative programme for the coming year to lawmakers with all the pomp and historic trappings that accompany the ceremonial opening of Parliament.

The question is whether Prime Minister Keir Starmer will be around to implement it and, even if he remains in post, whether he will have the authority to push his proposals through. The embattled prime minis-



ter has been urged to set a timetable for his departure by more than a fifth of the Labour Party's lawmakers in the House of Commons.

Some junior ministers have quit the Government in

Over 800 Russian drones target Ukraine

HANNA ARHIROVA/
BARRY HATTON
■ Kyiv

More than 800 Russian drones targeted areas of Ukraine on Wednesday, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said, hours after another barrage of missiles killed at least eight people.

"Russia continues its strikes and is doing so brazenly — deliberately targeting our railway infrastructure and civilian sites in our cities," Zelenskyy said in a post on X.

The overnight strikes targeted Ukraine's residential and railway infrastructure in the central Dnipro and northeastern Kharkiv regions, port infrastructure in the southern Odesa region, and energy facilities in the central Poltava region, according to Zelenskyy. On Tuesday, he said, 14 regions came under attack throughout the day.

"It is important to support Ukraine and not remain silent about Russia's war. Every time the war disappears from the top of the news, it encourages Russia to become even more savage," Zelenskyy said, in an apparent reference to world attention being

gripped by the Iran war. Moscow's attacks on its neighbour are unrelenting, even as Ukraine is emboldened by its recent military accomplishments and as US President Donald Trump and Russian President Vladimir Putin claim — without providing evidence — that the war could be approaching the end.

Trump said on Tuesday that he believes Moscow and Kyiv will soon reach a deal to end fighting.

"The end of the war in Ukraine, I really think, is getting very close," Trump told reporters as he departed the White House for a summit in Beijing. "Believe it or not, it's getting closer."

Putin said in a speech last weekend that his invasion of Ukraine is possibly "coming to an end."

Neither leader elaborated on what persuaded them about the possibility of peace in Europe's longest conflict since World War II. US-led diplomatic efforts over the past year to end the war have fizzled after making no progress on key issues, such as whether Russia gets to keep Ukrainian land and what can be done to deter Russia from invading again. (AP)



Mass protests in Argentina over Milei's university funding cuts



ALMUDENA CALATRAVA
■ Buenos Aires

Tens of thousands of Argentines flooded the streets of major cities nationwide on Tuesday to protest funding cuts by libertarian President Javier Milei to the public university system that represents a near-universal point of pride in this crisis-prone country.

Vast crowds in downtown Buenos Aires marched toward the Government headquarters to denounce budget shortfalls eroding the financial foundation of the country's higher education.

Argentina's public university system, a cornerstone of its well-educated workforce cherished by its large middle class, has

been tuition-free since 1949 and produced five Nobel Prize laureates. Congress passed a law last year to fund universities' operational costs and raise teacher salaries in line with high inflation. But the Government has not implemented it as it challenges the legislation in court.

Like his powerful backer and ally US President Donald Trump, Milei routinely attacks university campuses as bastions of "woke" indoctrination. He has slashed public education funding as part of his plan to take a chain saw to state funding in a sharp break from what he describes as decades of reckless spending that spawned corruption under his left-leaning predecessors. (AP)

12 hospitalised as torrential rains cause severe floods in Turkiye



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Ankara

Torrential rains have triggered severe flooding in a district near Turkiye's Black Sea coast, inundating homes and businesses and sweeping away cars. At least 12 people were hospitalised with minor injuries, the state-run Anadolu Agency reported.

The heavy rainfall late on Tuesday caused rivers in the Havza district of Samsun province to overflow, sending waters rushing down streets, carrying vehicles and debris.

Anadolu said the basement and ground floors of several properties were submerged. Video footage showed a driver standing on top of a truck waiting to be rescued from the flood.

Anadolu said none of the injured were in serious condition. Some reached the hospital on their own while others were assisted by medical teams.

Firefighters, police, and disaster teams were deployed to rescue stranded residents and to clear debris.

Macron faces backlash after interrupting Africa summit panel

MARK BANCHEREAU
■ Dakar (Senegal)

French President Emmanuel Macron is facing backlash after he interrupted a panel at the Africa Forward Summit in Kenya to demand silence from the audience.

Macron stormed the stage to rebuke audience members for what he called a "total lack of respect", accusing them of disrupting speakers during a presentation by artists and young entrepreneurs. He had earlier described himself as a "Pan-Africanist" during a news conference.

The summit is meant to showcase France's new policy for the continent - a shift from a former colonial power seen as dominating

to what Paris describes as a partnership of equals.

On Tuesday, Macron announced a \$27 billion investment into various sectors in Africa, including energy, artificial intelligence and agriculture.

Videos of Macron's heated intervention on Monday quickly spread across social media, drawing a mix of mockery, praise and criticism. Appearing visibly frustrated by the noise in the room, Macron abruptly walked onto the stage and asked the speaker to hand him the microphone, saying he would "restore order".

Addressing the audience in English, he criticised attendees for talking over the speakers and creating disruptions during the session.



Some audience members applauded the intervention, but Macron also drew criticism over his response.

"Just imagine what would happen if an African leader did the same thing in America or Europe," said Thierno Mbaye, a history student at a university in

Senegal's capital, Dakar.

"He acted like a school-teacher scolding children," Mbaye told *The Associated Press*. The intervention also drew criticism in France.

"It's stronger than him: as soon as he sets foot on the African continent, he can't help but behave like a

coloniser," Daniele Obono, a lawmaker for the hard-left party France Unbowed, said in a post on X.

The Africa Forward Summit, which is set to close on Tuesday with a declaration that is expected to be signed by all 30 heads of state, comes amid a fallout between France and its former colonies, mostly in West Africa. France has long maintained a colonial policy of economic, political and military sway dubbed *Francophonie*, which included keeping thousands of troops in the region it controlled. After years of criticism from leaders and opposition parties in many West African countries over what they described as a demeaning and heavy-handed

approach, France has withdrawn most of its troops from the region. It completed the withdrawal of troops from Senegal in July.

Macron had already faced a backlash ahead of the summit for claiming Sunday at news conference alongside Kenyan President William Ruto that "we are the true Pan-Africanists".

"We believe that Africa is a continent, and that this continent has an enormous amount to build," Macron said. Pan-Africanism refers to an ideology seeking the unity of Africans and the elimination of colonialism. Given France's colonial history across the continent, the remark went viral on social media and drew swift backlash. (AP)

Turkiye removes restriction on direct trade with Armenia to improve ties



SAJJAD HUSSAIN
■ Ankara

Turkiye removed a restriction on direct trade with Armenia on Wednesday in a symbolic gesture toward improved ties between the longtime rivals.

Turkiye and Armenia have no formal relations and their joint border has been closed since the 1990s. Relations between the neighbours have been strained over historic grievances and Turkiye's alliance with Azerbaijan.

Armenia and Turkiye agreed in late 2021 to work toward improving the relationship and appointed special envoys to discuss ways to reconcile and open the border. The efforts have resulted in the resumption of direct flights between the two countries and the easing of some visa restrictions.

Turkish Foreign Ministry Spokesman Onur Keceli said Wednesday on social media platform X that technical and bureaucratic work aimed at opening the shared border was continuing. (PTI)

Open Society Foundations commit \$30M to groups fighting antisemitism, anti-Muslim hate

JAMES POLLARD ■ New York



Open Society Foundations, the family philanthropy founded by hedge fund billionaire George Soros, is putting \$30 million toward groups fighting antisemitism and anti-Muslim hate over the next three years.

The major human rights funder pledged Wednesday to strengthen interfaith partnerships and protect those facing heightened threats in response to the rising levels of hate against both Jewish and Muslim communities, coinciding with the Israel-Hamas war and the current fragile ceasefire.

Last year saw the highest level of deadly violence

against Jews worldwide in over three decades, according to an annual study released last month by Tel Aviv University, including the December shooting at a Hanukkah celebration in Australia. Meanwhile, anti-

Muslim rhetoric has intensified against the backdrop of the Iran war, with one congressional Republican saying Muslims "don't belong in American society".

"The deep injustices occurring in the Middle East are

fuelling indiscriminate prejudice, dehumanisation, and violence directed against both Muslims and Jews," Open Society Foundations President Binaifer Nowrojee said in a statement.

"Entire communities cannot be targeted simply because of their religion. Bigotry and intolerance in any form must be called out and confronted."

The announcement marks the foundations' most visible campaign since last fall's reports that the US Department of Justice was considering possible charges against Open Society Foundations. President Donald Trump specifically named Soros as he ordered

the FBI to crack down on what he called "left-wing terrorism" - an accusation that OSF has denied in statements emphasizing their mission to strengthen democracy.

Alex Soros, who took over leadership of his father's foundations in late 2022, noted that "discrimination and hate" aren't abstract concepts for him as the son of a Holocaust survivor and husband to a Muslim American.

The foundation added that George Soros, who holds significant influence as a liberal megadonor with vast financial investments and philanthropic ties, is frequently targeted by conservative conspiracy theories that twist

those powerful connections into antisemitic tropes about behind-the-scenes puppet masters.

"At a moment like this we need to stand together and act," Alex Soros said in a pretaped video posted on social media. "This investment is about keeping people safe and pushing back against hate."

The commitment is aimed broadly at expanding education on forms of discrimination, supporting cross-community leaders who build trust and safeguarding free speech rights to lawful expression. The foundations have already selected some grantees and are inviting other nonprofits to apply for

funding. Recipients include the Jewish Social Justice Roundtable, the Jewish Council for Public Affairs and the Nexus Project. Shoulder to Shoulder, a multifaith alliance that prepares religious leaders to address anti-Muslim discrimination, is among those leading the work on Islamophobia.

Amy Spitalnick, the CEO of the Jewish Council for Public Affairs, welcomed the strategy to tackle both matters together.

The grant will allow JCPA to build upon its solidarity work with Muslim and Arab American communities, Spitalnick said, which have deepened since the start of the Israel-Hamas war. (AP)

BRIEFLY

Real Betis returns to Champions League after 20 years



Real Betis is back in the Champions League after a 20-year absence. The Spanish club beat Elche 2-1 at home in the Spanish league on Tuesday to seal fifth place and the final Champions League spot.

Betis last played in the Champions League in the 2005-06 season, when it finished third in its group behind Liverpool and Chelsea.

With two rounds remaining, Manuel Pellegrini's Betis opened a seven-point gap to sixth-place Celta Vigo, which earlier Tuesday lost 3-2 to Levante at home.

Cucho Hernandez put Betis ahead in the ninth minute and Pablo Fornals scored the winner in the 68th after Hector Fort had equalized for Elche shortly before halftime.

Elche, which played a man down from the 49th after Leo Petrot was sent off, stayed close to the relegation zone.

Levante moved to 16th place with its win over Vigo.

Also on Tuesday, fourth-place Atletico Madrid won 2-1 at 11th-place Osasuna with goals from Ademola Lookman and Alexander Sorloth. Atletico's Marcos Llorente was sent off in the 79th.

(AP)

Messi doubles MLS base salary



Lionel Messi more than doubled his salary to \$25 million in his new contract with Inter Miami and earns more more than twice as much as the second-highest-paid player in Major League Soccer, Los Angeles FC's Son Heung-min.

Messi's new contract includes \$25 million in base salary and \$28,333,333 in guaranteed compensation, the MLS Players Association said Tuesday in its first release of 2026 salaries. Miami's \$54.6 million payroll is more than \$20 million higher than LAFC, which is second at \$32.7 million, and nearly five times as much as Philadelphia's league-low \$11.7 million. Miami's payroll is up from \$46.8 million at the start of last season.

Toronto cut payroll to \$21.4 million from \$34.1 million at the start of 2025, and LAFC boosted its spending to \$32.7 million from \$22.4 million. Total league compensation was \$631 million and the average guaranteed compensation of \$688,816 on April 16 was up 8.9% from \$632,809 as of last Oct. 1. Messi's initial MLS contract, agreed to in July 2023, included a \$12 million base salary and annualized guaranteed compensation of \$20,446,667.

(AP)

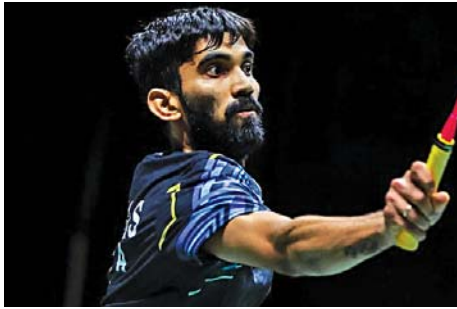
Srikanth and Sindhu advance in Thailand Open

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Bangkok

Star shuttlers Kidambi Srikanth and PV Sindhu progressed to the men's and women's singles second round with straight game wins in a mixed day for India at the Thailand Open Super 500 tournament here on Wednesday.

Srikanth, a former world number 1, stunned eighth seed Loh Kean Yew of Singapore 21-14 21-15 in 30 minutes, while Sindhu, a two-time Olympic medallist, saw off Tung Ciou-Tong of Chinese Taipei.

Srikanth will face Chinese Taipei's Su Li Yang, while Sindhu will meet Denmark's Amalie Schulz in the round of 16.



Former world number 1 Kidambi Srikanth stunned eighth seed Loh Kean Yew in straight games, while PV Sindhu cruised into the Thailand Open pre-quarterfinals

Ayush Shetty, a finalist at the Asia Championships, fought hard before going down 13-21 21-17 4-21 against Japan's sixth seed Kodai Naraoka, while Tharun Manneppalli lost 12-21 16-21 to another Japanese

Koki Watanabe. Unnati Hooda and Annol Kharb too displayed their fighting spirit before narrowly missing out against Thailand's fourth seed Pornpawee Chochuwong and second seed

Scheffler is looking to end streak of runner-up finishes with PGA Championship repeat

DOUG FERGUSON ■ Newtown Square

Scottie Scheffler is the defending champion at the PGA Championship and feeling like a bridesmaid over the last month. Runner-up to Rory McIlroy at the Masters. Playoff loss to Matt Fitzpatrick at the RBC Heritage. Runner-up (by six shots) to Cameron Young at Doral.

"Last week my wife was like, Hey, Scottie. You're like the first guy in PGA Tour history to have three solo runner-ups in a row. I'm like, Yeah, it's probably because the guy that was playing that good figured out a way to win one of those," Scheffler said on Tuesday.

It hasn't put much of a dent in his confidence going into the second major of the year. Scheffler is fierce when it comes to competition, hates losing even in friendly matches with his caddie and still has come to appre-



ciate that winning isn't always easy.

He has a firm hold on the number 1 world ranking — he is approaching three straight years at the top of golf — despite not winning since his season debut in the California desert.

"You know you're playing good golf, and you'd love to get some wins," he said. "Finishing second hurts, but I think when you reflect and you're looking at things to work on, there's a lot less to

clean up when you're finishing second than there is when you're finishing 30th."

Not that he has a lot of experience with the latter — Scheffler hasn't finished 30th or worse since August 2024.

To end that run of silver medal this week at Aronimink would allow him to join Brooks Koepka (2018-19) and Tiger Woods (1999-00 and 2006-07) as the only players to win back-to-back in the PGA Championship in stroke play.

(AP)

Ronaldo, Portugal get another shot at WC glory

ANNE M PETERSON ■ Lisbon

At 41, Cristiano Ronaldo realistically gets only one more shot at a World Cup trophy to cap an already illustrious career. A five-time Ballon d'Or winner, Ronaldo has more international goals than any other men's player, with 143 in 226 matches for Portugal.

He was slowed by a hamstring injury earlier this year with his club team, Al Nassr in the Saudi Pro League, and did not play for Portugal in a friendly against the United States in Atlanta on April 1.

Should he be named to the World Cup squad — and there's no reason to believe he won't unless he's injured — Ronaldo will play on American soil for the first time since a 2014 preseason friendly with Real Madrid against Manchester United in Michigan.

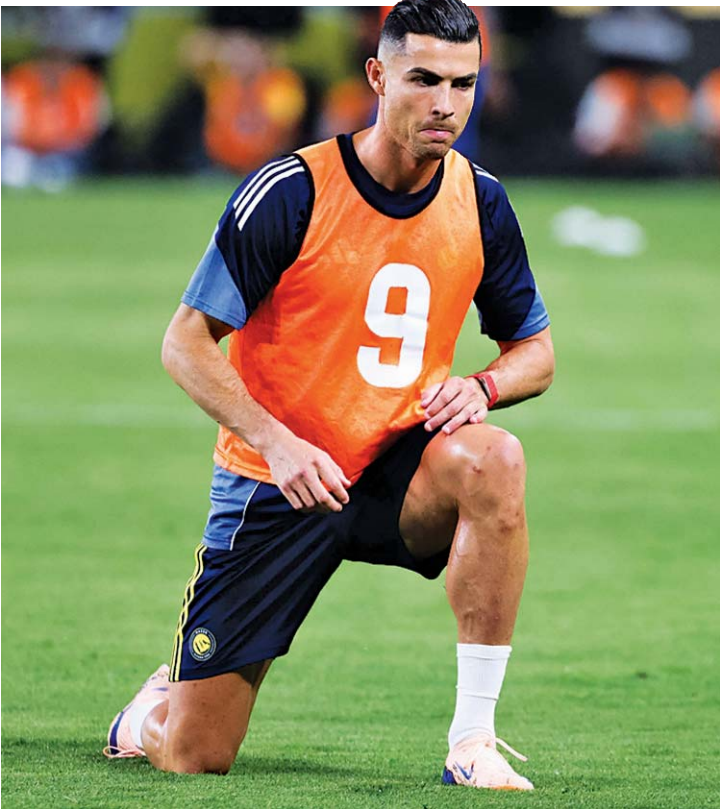
Ronaldo, along with his great rival Lionel Messi of Argentina, could become the first men to play in six World Cups.

Ronaldo told CNN in November that this one "definitely" would be his last World Cup.

Portugal is considered the top team in Group K, which includes Colombia, Uzbekistan and Congo.

Portugal

While Portugal is ranked number 5, the team got a wake-up



call in qualification with a 2-0 loss to Ireland last November, notable because Ronaldo was sent off with a red card for elbowing a defender. He was banned for the next

game — Portugal rebounded with a 9-1 victory over Armenia to seal its World Cup spot — but escaped more severe punishment.

This will be Portugal's ninth

Collin Morikawa in search of 2nd PGA title

BOB LENTZ ■ Newtown Square (US)

Collin Morikawa's start-and-stop season is a big go at the PGA Championship.

For now. The two-time major winner — and 2020 PGA champ — is still dealing with back issues that first surfaced after the opening hole of The Players Championship in March, forcing his first withdrawal of the 2026 season and sidetracking a torrid start that included his first victory in 28 months.

The seven-time PGA Tour winner, who withdrew from two other events, is dealing with an occasional cranky back and trying to learn to live with the accompanying uncertainty. "I wish I was 100 per cent healthy," the 29-year-old said.

"The body doesn't feel bad, just it's uncomfortable, and there's a trust factor. I'm kind of having to deal with ... I can't imagine wanting anyone to deal with it because it's just a very weird feeling of not trusting the body and yet knowing that



things are going to be OK. So, it's just taking it day by day, doing what I need to do."

The disappointing exit at TPC Sawgrass came after a great season-opening run. He won at Pebble Beach, finished tied for seventh at the Arnold Palmer Invitational. A week later, back spasms at The Players knocked him out of the championship, and the back has been a

consideration ever since.

Morikawa withdrew from the Texas Open ahead of the Masters and tied for seventh at Augusta National while dealing with back discomfort. The following week — again with back issues — he placed fourth at Hilton Head. Two weeks later, he finished down the leaderboard in a tie for 62nd in a signature, no-cut event at Doral.

Morikawa skipped last week's Trust Truist Championship, another signature

event. While that wasn't something he originally envisioned, he is learning to adjust on the fly.

"For me, even taking last week off, even though that wasn't really the plan, it's so big to just be able to reset sometimes and then come out and say, Oh, man, I'm ready to go."

He also is realizing there is more to golf than just his swing and has become more aware of his mental approach to the game. And, that's his focus at Aronimink as he chases another Wanamaker Trophy.

"The mental game is a big aspect of it," he said.

"You're able to push yourself that much farther. Trust me, it was very, very uncomfortable to play the Masters and very uncomfortable to play the week after at Hilton Head, but you just have to keep pushing.

Whatever the next week or weeks, I'm going to have to just breathe it out after this. Like, I will do everything it takes to play some great golf starting Thursday for four days.

(AP)

Rory McIlroy cuts practice short at PGA



BOB LENTZ, DOUG FERGUSON ■ Newtown Square (US)

Good thing Masters champion Rory McIlroy came to Aronimink a few weeks ago for a PGA Championship preview. His first practice round on Tuesday didn't last very long. He stopped after three holes because of ongoing blister issues under his right pinky toe.

McIlroy removed his shoe on the fourth tee, got into a cart and headed in. He looked a little better leaving the clubhouse, stopping to sign autographs and pose for a few pictures.

McIlroy had a limp Sunday at the Trust Truist Championship that he said was the result of a blister. That was his only tournament since winning the Masters in April.

"Yeah, I've got a blister on my pinky toe on my right foot, but it's underneath my nail," McIlroy said on Sunday.

"I can't really get to it, so it's a little sore. But I'll be all right."

McIlroy told Irish media earlier on Tuesday he had the nail removed and would be trying to find shoes to limit the discomfort. He has another day of practice - or

maybe rest - before the opening round of the PGA Championship.

Philadelphia has been very, very good to Justin Rose: Justin Rose feels at home in the Philadelphia suburbs.

Rose has a history of success on the Main Line as winner of the 2013 US Open at Merion and a great track record with a win and playoff loss at Aronimink.

The 45-year-old Englishman's second PGA Tour title came in the 2010 AT&T National. He lost to Keegan Bradley in a playoff at Aronimink in the 2018 BMW Championship. Sandwiched between those performances was his lone major victory.

Rose sounded a bit nostalgic explaining his repeated success in the region.

"I think the whole area feels very familiar to the part of England I live in," he said. "Very leafy, very green. Even this time of year I feel like the spring here is very much like the spring in England right now. So it feels very familiar from that point of view."

It's not just the change of seasons that seemingly puts Rose at ease. The old-fashioned course designs of Merion and Aronimink are part of it, too.

(AP)

Ronaldo made to wait for 1st Saudi league title after bizarre own-goal in final seconds

STEVE DOUGLAS FC ■ Washington

For Cristiano Ronaldo, winning a first league title in Saudi Arabia isn't coming easy. The Portugal superstar was a matter of seconds away from securing the victory needed to clinch the Saudi Pro League with Al-Nassr on Tuesday, with his team leading fierce rival Al-Hilal 1-0 in the eighth and final minute of stoppage time.

With Ronaldo looking nervous on the bench — the 41-year-old striker had been substituted by that point — and some Al-Nassr fans hardly able to watch, Al-Hilal sent a long throw-in into the area and Al-Nassr goalkeeper Bento, in an attempt to catch the ball, fumbled it backward and into his own net.

The match finished 1-1, the title race was still alive and Ronaldo looked distraught



as he sat in the dugout, consoled by teammates.

"The dream is close," Ronaldo wrote in a post to his more than 100 million followers on X after the match. "Heads up, we have one more step to take!"

Al-Nassr hasn't won the Saudi league since 2019, more than three years before Ronaldo joined the club in a game-changing signing for the country as it looked to become a major player in world soccer.

(AP)

Tiger Woods' prescription drug records will be handed over to prosecutors in Florida DUI case

DAVID FISCHER ■ Stuart (US)

Tiger Woods' prescription drug records will be handed over to prosecutors following his March arrest in Florida on suspicion of driving under the influence, a judge ruled.

Judge Darren Steele approved an agreement between Woods' defense attorney and prosecutors following a four-minute hearing in Martin County circuit court, just north of Palm Beach County on Tuesday.

Prosecutors had issued a subpoena seeking copies of all prescription medication records for the legendary golfer at a Palm Beach pharmacy from the start of the year through the end of March. Defense attorney Doug Duncan had previously argued that Woods has a constitutional right to privacy when it comes to his prescription medications, but he acknowledged during



the hearing that the right is not absolute and that prosecutors could make a compelling argument for why they were needed.

Meanwhile, prosecutors agreed to Duncan's request for a protective order limiting the release of records only to prosecutors, law enforcement officers, state experts and Woods' defense team.

Bob Jarvis, a law professor at Nova Southeastern University who is not connected to the case, said the agreement and the judge's

approval seems normal for DUI case, particularly one that involves drugs instead of alcohol. Florida law considers a driver with a blood-alcohol content of 0.08 per cent or higher to be impaired, but there's no clear, measurable standard to determine impairment for other drugs.

That means prosecutors will have to use field sobriety tests, officer testimony and other evidence to convince jurors beyond a reasonable doubt that Woods was impaired.

(AP)

Kohli's ton helps RCB walk over KKR

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Raipur

Virat Kohli bounced back from a lean patch in the previous two matches with a classy unbeaten century as Royal Challengers Bengaluru cruised to a six-wicket win over Kolkata Knight Riders in their IPL clash here on Wednesday.

Chasing 193 for victory, Kohli smashed an unbeaten 105 off 60 balls, studded with 11 boundaries and three sixes, and shared a match-defining 92-run partnership for the second wicket with Devdutt Padikkal (37 off 27 balls) to guide RCB to win in 19.1 overs.

Following the win, RCB climbed to the top of the table with 16 points, level with Gujarat Titans but ahead on net run rate.

Earlier in the game, Angkrish Raghuvanshi led the charge with his career-best 71 as Kolkata Knight Riders posted a commanding 192 for four against Royal Challengers Bengaluru in their rain-delayed Indian Premier League clash here on Tuesday.

The KKR wicketkeeper-batter



struck three sixes and seven fours in a fluent knock off 46 balls while forging crucial partnerships along the way to give his side the necessary impetus, which their openers had failed to provide.

With a wet outfield delaying the contest by more than an hour, RCB

opted to field in search of early assistance, but there was no particular help for the seamers as compared to the last game here when new ball had made its impact.

KKR lost momentum as soon as they had found some. After a tight first over in which Ajinkya Rahane

(19) found a boundary after five dot balls off Bhuvneshwar Kumar, Finn Allen (18) smacked 14 runs off Jacob Duffy in the second.

But RCB struck back hard with Bhuvneshwar getting Allen caught behind off a delivery that darted away from the batter, and Josh Hazlewood bounced out Rahane in the fourth over soon after the KKR skipper had hit a six and a four off Duffy to make it 17 runs off the fourth over.

With KKR crawling to 56 for two after the powerplay, Raghuvanshi put on vital 68 runs for the third wicket with Cameron Green (32) and another 76 runs for the fourth wicket with Rinku Singh (49 not out) to help put on a competitive total on the board.

The 21-year-old Raghuvanshi struck his fourth half-century of the season which has been his best so far in the IPL, thriving at the No.3 slot while also having a long stint behind the wickets.

He began with an imperious hit over wide long-on for a six and kept picking the odd boundaries during the two partnerships that he forged.

PBKS look to arrest slide against MI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dharamshala

Punjab Kings will need to plug gaping holes in the bowling and fielding department as they look to stop their free-fall in the business end of the Indian Premier League against an already eliminated Mumbai Indians here on Thursday.

After bossing the first half of the tournament, Punjab Kings have lost four games in a row and now find themselves in a precarious position in the race for play-offs.

They need to win at least two of their remaining games to secure a place in the top four. It was not so long ago that they were the only unbeaten team in the tournament but such is the nature of the format and the IPL that fortunes can swing either way rather quickly.

As captain Shreyas Iyer pointed out after the loss to Delhi



Capitals, Punjab Kings only have themselves to blame for being in a difficult spot.

The in-form batting unit masked the frailties in the bowling department in the first half of the tournament but more recently, even posting an above par score, by Iyer's own admission, has not been enough against Delhi Capitals.

ICC Test Rankings: Bumrah maintains top spot



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dubai

India's pace spearhead Jasprit Bumrah maintained his pole position among Test bowlers in the latest ICC rankings published on Wednesday. Yashasvi Jaiswal and Shubman Gill were placed 8th and 9th among the batters respectively with former England Test skipper Joe Root leading the charts with 880 points.

Jaiswal has 750 points and Gill, who has climbed a spot, has accumulated 730 points. Harry Brook is second in the list followed by Travis Head and Steve Smith respectively.

It must be noted that India is yet to play any of their WTC matches in 2026 having last played against South Africa at home in the month of November.

In the bowlers' list, Bumrah is still leading the charts with 879 points while the next best Indian is Mohammed Siraj placed 12th. Ravindra Jadeja and Kuldeep Yadav are currently placed 14th and 15th respectively.

Australia's Mitchell Starc and Test captain Pat Cummins have gained to spot to second and fourth place respectively, while New Zealand's Matt Henry also leapfrogged to third spot.

IPL play-offs race: GT and RCB on course for top-two finish

BHARAT SHARMA ■ New Delhi

A late revival by the likes of Chennai Super Kings and Kolkata Knight Riders means there are as many as eight teams in contention for the four play-off berths with 10 days left for the league stage to wind up in the Indian Premier League.

Defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru and the consistent Gujarat Titans were expected to make the play-offs before the start of the tournament. Now, SunRisers Hyderabad too are a part of the leading pack after making a slow start to the competition.

What has been most unexpected is the rapid slide of Punjab Kings, who have lost four games in a row to be precariously placed after dominating the first half of the league. Mumbai Indians and Lucknow Super Giants are the two teams which have been eliminated. PTI looks at the qualifying scenarios for the eight teams in contention.

Royal Challengers Bengaluru:

The Rajat Patidar-led side has managed to retain the consistency that resulted in its first ever IPL title last year following a rather long wait.

They play KKR on Wednesday night and a win would ensure that they have one foot in the play-offs. RCB would need another win to secure a last four spot with 18 points being the safer number compared to 16. Only Mumbai Indians qualified with 16 points last season.

With 14 points from seven wins in 11 games, RCB have the best net



run rate among the teams in contention. After KKR, they play Punjab Kings and SunRisers Hyderabad in their last two league fixtures.

Punjab Kings:

Poor bowling and fielding have resulted in four straight losses for Punjab Kings who remain in the top four owing to their stellar run in the first half of IPL.

Thanks to their in form line-up, their net run rate remains healthy and two wins out of their remaining three games against

Mumbai Indians, RCB and SRH should be enough to advance in the competition.

They have 13 points from 11 matches with one point coming from a washout against KKR. The game against Mumbai Indians in Dharamshala is a must win one for them, else they will be under enormous pressure going into the final two matches.

Gujarat Titans:

Since their debut in 2022, Gujarat Titans have not made the play-offs only once. With a bowling line up firing on all cylinders and a solid top three, the Shubman Gill-led side is on course to secure a top two qualification.

They have 16 points from eight wins in 12 games, almost sealing a play-off berth. Their last two matches are against KKR and Chennai Super Kings.

Sunrisers Hyderabad:

With six wins in their last eight games, SRH is another team that seems to be peaking at the right time. The belligerent batting line-up has done the job and has been supported well by bowlers led by Pat Cummins.

They are on 14 points with two games to go against CSK and RCB. SRH would need at least two more points if not four to make

the play-offs with their net run rate of 0.031 also in their favour. Their fifth loss in 12 games came against Gujarat Titans on Tuesday night.

Chennai Super Kings:

Having lost their first three games, CSK bounced back with six wins in their last eight matches. They would back themselves to collect two points against Lucknow Super Giants on May 15 before taking on SRH and Gujarat Titans in their final two league games.

Only 18 points will ensure qualification with teams in contention



Delhi's hopes hang by a thread though the Axar Patel-led side has already started planning for the next season. Despite the win over Punjab Kings, they have too much to do to make the play-offs. They sit on 10 points from 12 games and can reach a maximum of 14 points. Even wins with big margins may not be enough. (PTI)

Gyaneshwari bags 2 medals at Asian Senior

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Gandhinagar

India's Gyaneshwari Yadav bagged a double by winning silver and bronze medals in the 53kg category at the 2026 Asian Senior Weightlifting Championships here on Wednesday.

Gyaneshwari won a silver in the snatch section and then an overall bronze medal in the event with a combined lift of 194kg. The gold medal in the category was claimed



by Jinlan Zhao of China with a total lift of 216kg, while the silver went to Vietnam's Hoai Huong Nguyen with a total of 195kg. Komal Kohar had opened India's medal count, winning a bronze in the women's 48kg on Monday.

The championships, which started on Monday at the Mahatma Mandir & Exhibition Centre features 178 lifters from 28 Asian nations and two Commonwealth countries and serves as a qualifying event for the 2026 Commonwealth Games.

Cummins fined for slow over rate

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Ahmedabad

Sunrisers Hyderabad skipper Pat Cummins has been fined for maintaining a slow over rate in the game against Gujarat Titans in an IPL match here.

Cummins was penalised ₹12 lakh. "As this was his team's first offence of the season under Article 2.22 of the IPL's Code of Conduct, which pertains to minimum over-rate offences, Cummins was fined INR 12 lakhs," the IPL said in a statement.



SRH suffered a crushing 82-run loss against GT at the Narendra Modi Stadium on Tuesday night. Chasing GT's 168 for five, SRH were bundled out for a paltry 86 in 14.5 overs.

Zoravar Singh out of India's Asian Games shooting squad



AJAI MASAND ■ New Delhi

Asia's No. 1 and world No. 6 trap shooter Zoravar Singh Sandhu has been left out of the proposed Indian shotgun contingent for this year's Asian Games despite the fact that the veteran shooter is one of top trap shooter in the country and clinched a bronze medal at the prestigious World Championships last year.

Zoravar endured a dip in form during the National Championships and domestic selection trials — events he was required to compete in despite being on a relentless international schedule in preparation for the World

Championships and World Cup Finals.

Those underwhelming scores in the national trials ultimately cost him a place in the Asian Games-bound squad, even though he was ranked world No. 4 barely a month ago.

Zoravar has urged the National Rifle Association of India (NRAI) to "review" its decision, pointing out that he has registered the best international scores among Indian trap shooters over the last six months. The federation, however, has maintained that it will "strictly go by the selection policy put in place one or one-and-a-half years ago". (PTI)

Mohun Bagan's ex-chief Tutu Bose dies at 79

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Former Mohun Bagan President Swapnan Sadhan Bose, fondly known as "Tutu Babu" in Kolkata's Maidan circles, has died after suffering a cardiac arrest. He was 79.

Bose is survived by his sons Srinjay and Soumik. Srinjay is the current Mohun Bagan secretary. Bose, one of the most influential figures in Indian football administration, had been undergoing treatment at a private hospital here for multiple health complications. He died



around 11.45 pm on Tuesday, according to family sources.

His mortal remains will be kept at the Mohun Bagan club tent on Wednesday for fans and sports lovers to pay their last respects. The cremation will take place at 4.30 pm later in the day.

Patience, simplicity worked on a sticky wicket: Kagiso Rabada

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ahmedabad

Following the example set by Sunrisers Hyderabad bowlers and sticking to Test-match lines and lengths with patience and simplicity worked in his favour, said Gujarat Titans pacer Kagiso Rabada after their massive win here on Tuesday.

Gujarat Titans rose to the No. 1 spot in the IPL 2026 points table with an 82-run hammering of the Sunrisers Hyderabad in their clash here on Tuesday.

With Kagiso Rabada returning 3/28, Jason Holder



claiming 3/20 and Mohammed Siraj taking 1/11, the visitors were shot out for 86 in 14.5 overs in reply to Gujarat Titans' 168 for five.

"Season in, season out, all you try to do is do the best you can. I have been backed and it has been clear what my role has been: leave everything out for the team. Rhythm is everything," Rabada told the broadcaster after the match.

"100 per cent," he replied when asked if Test match length was the right approach with the ball.

"They showed how to

bowl on it and we tried to follow suit. Wicket got a little more sticky and patience and simplicity worked," he added.

Talking about his bowling partnerships with the other pacers, Rabada said understanding the nature of the pitch becomes imperative for their success.

"(It is) about bowling as much as I can but also preserving myself to be match ready. Need to find a way to somehow click, (it is) just about finding out the kind of pitch we are playing on and bowling accordingly," he said.